

Inversion, Priority, and A-Locality

Abstract: This paper documents and analyzes a pattern of selective A-attraction in Mandarin, a verb-initial ergative language of Sulawesi (Austronesian). It shows that the head at the edge of the clause-internal phase defines an A-position that typically attracts the highest Caseless DP in the *voiceP*, then demonstrates that this argument is invariably passed up whenever the phase head can attract a pronoun or quantified argument from further below. In spite of this selectivity, the paper shows that the ensuing step of movement is fully integrated into the A-syntax, breaking from putative steps of mixed A- $\bar{A}$ attraction (Webelhuth 1989a; Van Urk 2015). It then goes on to build a theory of the fine conditions that allow the rules of A-locality to be relaxed—building from prior work on inversions in the A-syntax (Miyagawa, 2001; Bailyn, 2004), BEST-MATCH effects in agreement (Coon & Bale, 2014; Oxford, 2014, 2019), and a particular type of Anti-Agreement effect (Ouhalla, 1993) to argue that a second type of A-movement must emerge at the edge of the phase.

Keywords:

Inversion, Locality, Activity, A- $\bar{A}$ Mixing, Improper Movement, Austronesian

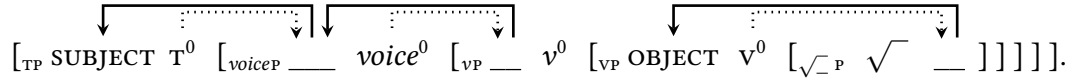
Related Works: None

1 Introduction

When we speak of the A-syntax in contemporary minimalism, we speak of a system defined by the regular interaction of two component parts: the consistent needs of nominal arguments and the consistent needs of the clausal spine. The first of these, since Vergnaud 1977, has been understood primarily in terms of abstract Case: nominal arguments enter the derivation with needs that drive them into particular structural relationships with the heads of the extended VP and TP (Larson, 1988; Pollock, 1989). The second component, in turn, has been gradually reworked from the theory of Chomsky 1965 (which defined the positions of arguments in phrase-structure rules) to the framework familiar today: one on which general principles force the construction of a stable clausal spine (Grimshaw, 1991) that introduces arguments in consistent positions (Baker, 1988) and drives patterns of Case assignment, agreement, and attraction in response to the language-specific properties of individual heads (Chomsky, 1981; Borer, 1984). The work of A-syntax, on this understanding, is to establish consistent relationships between heads and arguments in consistent positions to resolve these paired networks of regular and predictable needs.

As the nature of this system has come into focus, the steps of movement that it drives have been recognized to show a fairly consistent shape: they strictly target nominals, reshape patterns of pronominal coreference and variable binding, and feed higher steps of Case assignment, ϕ -agreement, and A-attraction (for a recent overview, see Saifir 2019). Chief among their properties, however, is a restriction on relative locality (Rizzi, 1990): A-movement generally does not cross over intervening nominal arguments. Subjects and objects, for instance, now seem to raise along paths of the shape in (1): they are drawn through strings of tightly interconnected A-positions by successive steps of strictly local attraction that never cross over intervening DPs (Koopman & Sportiche, 1988; Johnson, 1991; McCloskey, 1997; Cardinaletti, 2004).

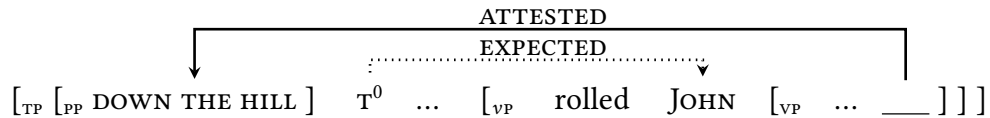
(1) *A-movement: Strict Locality*



Against this backdrop, it comes as an architectural mystery that there are many cases where this usual pattern of movement is derailed: cases where the heads of the A-syntax skip over the targets in the usual launching sites of A-movement to attract special elements in non-canonical launching sites further below. This is the pattern that seems to manifest in cases of locative inversion in English (Collins, 1996), and it occurs equally in a range of systems documented early in the history of the Minimalism—from scrambling in Japanese (Miyagawa, 2001) to the Generalized Inversions known from Russian (Bailyn, 2003, 2004). This type of pattern, shown in (2), raises three fundamental questions about the A-syntax:

- (i) what allows the A-syntax to forego its usual pattern of locality and skip the highest DP,
- (ii) how does the A-syntax ensure that Case is still assigned to DPs skipped in this way, and
- (iii) what principles drive the A-syntax to target the particular goals that it raises instead?

(2) *Inversions in the A-Syntax*

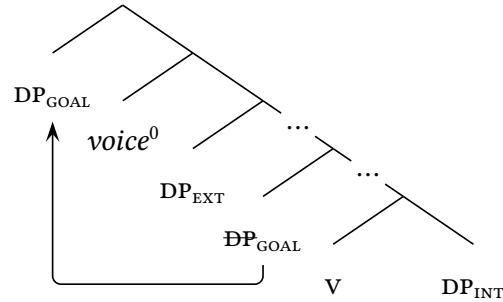


To answer these questions, the task of this paper is to document and analyze a series of inversions that play out in the A-syntax of Mandarin, an Austronesian language of Indonesia. This is a language where the head that falls at the edge of the clause-internal phase, *voice*⁰, defines a low subject position that systematically attracts the absolutive DP. Across all the DP-DP ditransitives of the language, this head canonically attracts the applied argument, yielding the syntax in (3a). But this pattern is systematically derailed when the applied argument is a regular DP and the internal argument belongs to a class of special targets,

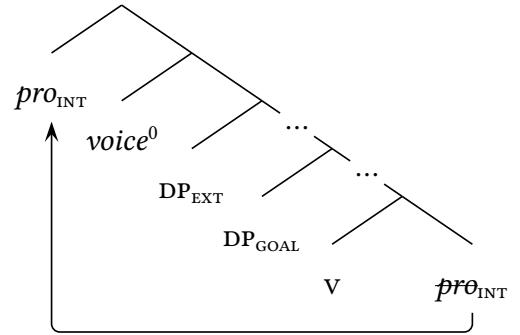
including pronouns and quantified expressions, which are treated with a type of **PRIORITY**. When the internal argument is a member of this class—henceforth a **PRIORITY PARCEL**—it is systematically drawn up to *SPEC,voiceP* instead, yielding the step of inversion in (3b).

(3) *The Pattern in Mandar*

a. *Ditransitives: Regular Syntax*



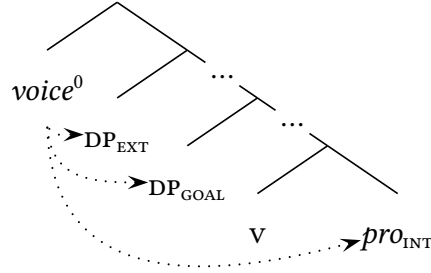
b. *Priority Parcels: Inversion*



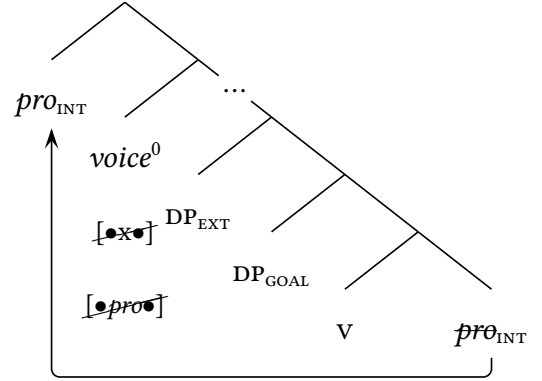
To derive these effects, this paper puts forward a revised theory of A-attraction: one that derives priority effects and inversion from a type of non-local A-movement that emerges at the edge of the phase. Building from work on ϕ -agreement, it argues that A-movement must be prefigured by a process that links movement-driving heads with all possible goals in their search space (Miyagawa, 2001). It then argues that the targets for attraction must be weighed against each other in a local calculus of economy (Collins, 1996; Van Urk & Richards, 2015): one that can rank the pressure for strict locality beneath a requirement of **BEST MATCH** (Coon & Bale, 2014; Oxford, 2014, 2019) to yield patterns of priority attraction like (4). It then demonstrates that priority effects must be able to emerge fully within A-syntax: unlike the best candidates for mixed A- $\bar{A}$ -attraction, the priority movements in this system feed higher steps of A-movement and ϕ -agreement. The ensuing inversions must then emerge from the interplay of two ingredients: a positional loosening of A-locality and a specific type of flexibility in the system of Case.

(4) *The Structure of Inversion*

a. *Starting Paths for Attraction*



b. *Multitasking + Priority*



The remainder of this paper is structured as follows. Section 2 reviews the clausal syntax of Mandar, introduces the DP-DP ditransitive, and lays out the priority effect in the pronominal system. Section 3 develops a new theory of A-attraction to capture this effect, building from insights in the literature on AGREE. Section 4 argues that priority attraction must operate within the A-syntax, drawing contrasts with the movements that straddle the A- $\bar{A}$ divide, and then develops a theory of the conditions that license non-local A-movement. Section 5 then turns to the matter of Case and shows that these priority effects are bound up with shifts in agreement, building an analysis of secondary licensors that turns on a particular type of Anti-Agreement Effect. Section 6 then concludes.

2 Background

Mandar is an Austronesian language spoken by 400,000 people in the Indonesian province of West Sulawesi. It belongs to the South Sulawesi subfamily of Malayo-Polynesian (Esser, 1938; Mills, 1975; Grimes & Grimes, 1987) and has been the subject of a range of descriptive studies in Indonesian (Pelenkahu *et al.*, 1983; Sikki *et al.*, 1987; Muthalib & Sangi, 1991), and it can be productively compared to the other language of the South Sulawesi subgroup,

which have been described in a much larger body of work (Friberg, 1991, 1996; Strømme, 1994; Matti, 1994; Valkama, 1995a,b; Jukes, 2006; Lee, 2008; Kaufman, 2008; Laskowske, 2016; Finer, 1994, 1997, 1998, 1999; Béjar, 1999). This paper describes the standard variety of the language, spoken on the coast between the cities of Polewali and Majene (Grimes & Grimes, 1987), and its central results emerge from elicitation with a single speaker, Jupri Talib, with whom I have been working since 2018.¹

Mandar is a verb-initial language that requires nominal arguments to surface in a rigid order in the extended VP: the EXTERNAL ARGUMENT (EXT) must precede the INTERNAL ARGUMENT (INT) and in ditransitives, the INT must precede the APPLIED ARGUMENT (GOAL). I will refer to this order as vsOD. The language shows no morphological case-marking, but it has a system of agreement: the EXT controls ergative agreement on transitive and ditransitive verbs, while the transitive INT and ditransitive GOAL are targeted by absolutive agreement enclitics in second position. These properties are shown in example (5).

(5) *The Mandar Clause*

Na-alli-ang	i	[_{EXT} iKaco']	[_{INT} iGary]	[_{GOAL} iCicci']	dionging.
3ERG-buy-APPL	3ABS	NAME	NAME	NAME	yesterday

'Kacho' bought Gary (a cat) for Chichi' yesterday.'

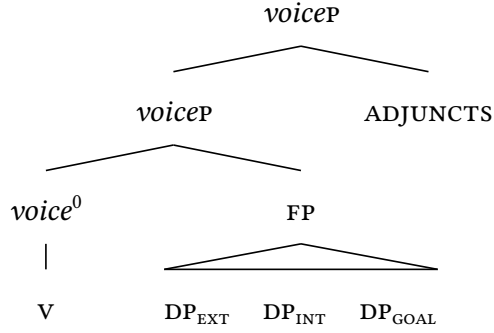
2.1 The Mandar Clause

We can begin to map out the syntax of the clause with a fact of constituency. In the general case in Mandar, the vsOD string forms a tight constituent: one that can be detected in the syntax from patterns of ellipsis and predicate clefting and one that corresponds to a tight

¹GLOSSING: ABS: absolutive, ACC: accusative, AF: agent focus, APPL: applicative, ERG: ergative, FIN: finite; FUT: future; GEN: genitive; NOM: nominative; PL: plural; TRANS: transitive. <c, ng, '>: /tʃ, ŋ, ʔ/.

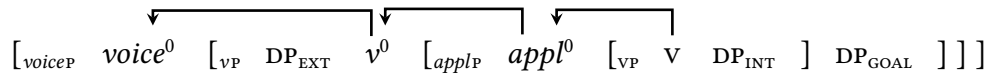
phonological domain in the surface prosody. [Brodkin 2025b](#) identifies this constituent as the *voiceP* and proposes that clauses like (5) show the rough syntax in (6).

(6) *The VSOD Constituent*



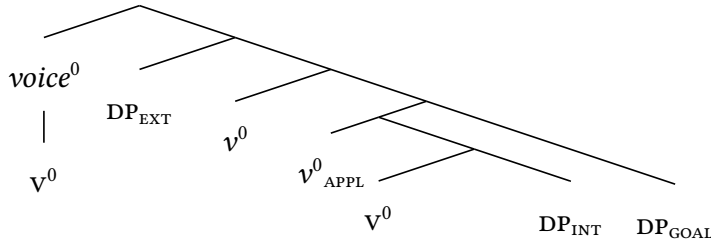
From this position, [Brodkin 2025c](#) argues that the verb reaches its high position through a process of head-movement that carries it through the extended *vP*. Within this space, the surface prosody reveals the existence of two smaller projections, and these correspond neatly to two lower heads that are morphologically expounded in the verbal complex ([Brodkin, 2025b](#), [To Appear](#)): *appl*⁰, which introduces GOALS ([Pylkkänen, 2008](#)), and *v*⁰, which introduces the EXT ([Collins, 2005](#); [Merchant, 2013](#)). On the view that the verb raises to the head at the very edge of the extended *vP*, we thus arrive at the analysis in (7): one that derives the consistent and stable order of *vso(D)* from head-movement up to *voice*⁰.

(7) *VSOD Order: Head-Movement of the Verb*



We can now turn to a linear quirk of the head *appl*⁰: despite the basic order of *vsoD*, there is clear evidence that the *INT* originates beneath the *GOAL* and typically remains below it in the *voiceP* ([Brodkin, 2022](#)). This fact will play a central role in the investigation that follows, and anticipating the work that will lead us to that result, we can resolve the apparent tension between hierarchy and linear order by placing the *GOAL* in a specifier that is linearized to the right. We thus begin from the *voiceP*-level syntax in (8).

(8) *The Extended VP*



With the shape of the extended VP in place, we can now turn to the syntax of subjecthood. Above the *voiceP*, Mandar has a closed class of five rigidly ordered elements that mark polarity and aspect: the negator *ndang*, the experiential perfect *rua*, the completive *yari*, the habitual *byasa*, and the terminative *pura* (9). Brodtkin 2025a establishes that these elements form a coherent class of functional heads in the middle field, and I will refer to them as AUXILIARIES below.

(9) *The System of Auxiliaries*

[_{POLP} *Ndang i* [_{AUXP2} *rua* [_{AUXP1} *yari* [_{voiceP} *na-baca*]]]].
 not 3ABS ever DID 3ERG-read
 ‘She never DID read it.’

The enclitics that spell out absolutive agreement always follow the highest overt AUX, as across the South Sulawesi subfamily (Strømme, 1994; Friberg, 1996; Finer, 1999); otherwise they follow the verb. This pattern then falls together with several other facts to suggest that absolutive agreement sits very high in the Mandar clause: for instance, it surfaces in all finite clauses, shows allomorphy conditioned by c^0 (10a), and vanishes in the clauses that lack the higher structure of the middle field—such as control complements like (10b). It contrasts in these respects with ergative agreement, which is strictly verb-adjacent, shows no parallel type of allomorphy, vanishes in clauses that lack transitive verbs, and appears in reduced complements of these types. As a result, Brodtkin 2022 argues that absolutive agreement sits in T^0 and ergative agreement sits in *voice*⁰.

(10) *Absolutive Agreement* $\rightarrow T^0$

- a. Pole **a'** yau marondong **anna'-u** mala mu-ita.
 come 1ABS 1SG tomorrow so.that-1ABS.IRREALIS can 2ERG-see
 'I'll come tomorrow so that you might see me.'
- b. Tapi' batabata **a'** [_{polP} na-ita (***a'**) kindo'-u].
 but reluctant 1ABS 3ERG-see 1ABS mom-1GEN
 'But I'm reluctant ____ for my mom to see me.'

This initial asymmetry is then mirrored in the positions of the absolutive and ergative DPs. Despite the consistent basic word order of VSOD, there is a context in which the argument that triggers absolutive agreement—henceforth the absolutive DP—surfaces farther to the left. This is one that can be seen most easily in the clauses that host auxiliaries, where the absolutive DP typically follows the verb (11a). When the prosodic shape of the *voiceP* is manipulated in just the right way, the absolutive DP is forced into a second position: one that falls just above the verb. In transitive *voicePs* like (11b), this position hosts the INT. Following Brodtkin 2025a, I will refer to this as ABSOLUTIVE PREPOSING.

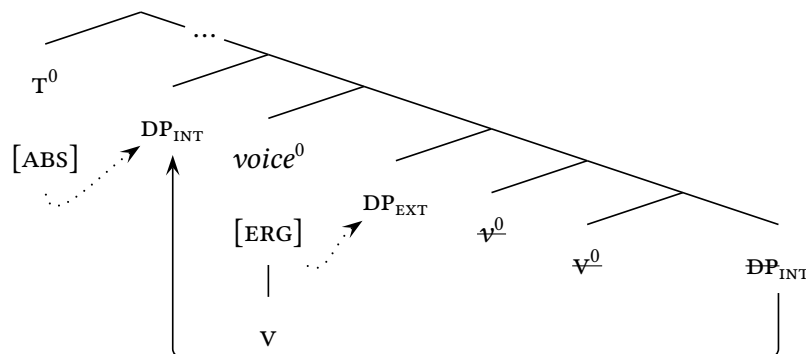
(11) *Absolutive Preposing*

- a. Rua i yari [_{voiceP} na-saka [_{INT} iAli]].
 once 3ABS DID 3ERG-catch NAME
 'They once DID arrest Ali.'
- b. Rua i yari [_{voiceP} [_{INT} iAli] na-saka [_{EXT} polisi] ____].
 once 3ABS DID NAME 3ERG-catch police
 'The police once DID arrest Ali.'

This fact of order then converges with a much wider network of patterns, reviewed in Sections 2.2-2.3, to suggest that the absolutive DP invariably raises above the ergative DP. More specifically, Brodtkin 2025c argues for the syntax in (12): one on which the absolutive DP raises to a LOW SUBJECT POSITION at the edge of the *voiceP*. In the default case, this step of movement is covert and the absolutive DP is spelled out in its base position, yielding the

order vsOD. But under the conditions that force Absolutive Preposing, that DP is spelled out high—yielding linear evidence for movement to SPEC,*voiceP*.

(12) *The Low Subject Position*



2.2 The Syntax of The Ditransitive

From this position, we can now advance to the ditransitive. Mandar has a range of DP-DP ditransitive constructions, and all of these share two properties: they require applicative suffixes on the verb and they force the *voiceP*-level word order of vsOD (Brodkin, 2022). The following example illustrates this effect with a *voiceP* built around the root *jolo* “show,” which shows the typical behavior of all ditransitive verbs in the language.

(13) *The DP-DP Ditransitive*

Na-yolo-ang i [EXT iKaco'] [INT iGary] [GOAL iCicci'] dionging.
 3ERG-show-APPL 3ABS NAME NAME NAME yesterday
 ‘Kacho’ showed Gary (a cat) to Chichi’ yesterday.’

To see into the syntax of this construction, we can begin from the facts of linear order. When we embed ditransitive *voiceP*s beneath middle-field auxiliaries, we can recreate the configuration that forces the movement of absolutive DPs to be overt. In this context, we consistently encounter the following shift: the position we have identified as SPEC,*voiceP* must attract the GOAL (14a). It is ungrammatical for this position to attract the INT (14b).

(14) *DP-DP Ditransitives: Absolute Argument = Goal*

- a. Rua i yari [_{voiceP} [_{GOAL} iCicci'] na-yolo-ang [_{INT} formulir] ____].
 once 3ABS DID NAME 3ERG-show-APPL form
 'He once DID show Chichi' the forms.'
- b. *Rua i yari [_{voiceP} [_{INT} formulir] na-yolo-ang ____ [_{GOAL} iCicci']].
 once 3ABS DID form 3ERG-show-APPL NAME
 INTENDED: 'He once DID show Chichi' the forms.'

This linear asymmetry then correlates with a series of restrictions on variable binding which suggest, even in clauses of the order VOD, that the GOAL must raise to SPEC,*voiceP*. The case begins from the binding possibilities that emerge around arguments quantified by *nasang* “every,” a quantifier that remains adnominal in many types of reduced clause: for instance, the *voiceP*-sized complements of *though*, which lack absolute agreement.

(15) *The Universal Quantifier Nasang “Every”*

- Mau** [_{voiceP} na-yolo-ang [_s pallukis **nasang**] [_o lukisang] [_D iCicci']],
 though 3ERG-show-APPL painter every painting NAME
 'Though every painter showed [–FIN] Chichi' a painting.'

This type of quantification licenses a series of binding possibilities that strictly track c-command and ignore linear order (Brodkin 2022; see also Reinhart 1983). To begin, it yields a familiar asymmetry between the ditransitive EXT and INT: the EXT can bind into the INT (16a), but the INT cannot bind into the EXT (16b). This fact fits naturally with the view that the EXT originates and remains above the INT in the ditransitive *voiceP*.

(16) *Variable Binding: Ditransitive EXT > INT*

- a. Mau [_{voiceP} na-yolo-ang [_s pallukis **nasang**] [_o lukisang-na *pro*] [_D iCicci']],
 though 3ERG-show-APPL painter every painting-3GEN her NAME
 'Though every_{i,j} painter showed [–FIN] Chichi' her_i painting.'

- b. Mau [_{voip} na-yolo-ang [_s pallukis-na *pro*] [_o lukisang **nasang**] [_D iCicci']],
 though 3ERG-show-APPL painter-3GEN its painting every NAME
 ‘Though its_{i,j} painter showed [–FIN] Chichi’ every_i painting,’

We can then see the same type of asymmetry between the ditransitive INT and GOAL. When the GOAL is quantified, it can bind into the preceding INT (17a), running against the facts of linear order. When the INT is quantified, in the same vein, it cannot bind into the following GOAL (17b). We can understand this asymmetry in much the same way: across ditransitive *voiceps*, the GOAL strictly originates and remains above the INT.

(17) *Variable Binding: Ditransitive GOAL > INT*

- a. Mau [_{voip} na-yolo-ang [_s iCicci'] [_o lukisang-na *pro*] [_D pallukis **nasang**]],
 though 3ERG-show-APPL NAME painting-3GEN her painter every
 ‘Though Chichi’ showed [–FIN] every_{i,j} painter her_i painting,’
 b. Mau [_{voip} na-yolo-ang [_s iCicci'] [_o lukisang **nasang**] [_D pallukis-na *pro*]],
 though 3ERG-show-APPL NAME painting every painter-3GEN its
 ‘Though Chichi’ showed [–FIN] its_{i,j} painter every_i painting,’

The key asymmetries in this system emerge around the absolute DP, which can always bind into every other argument in the *voicep*. The ditransitive GOAL can bind into the EXT (18), suggesting that it must raise above it. The transitive INT shows the same privilege, suggesting that it moves in the same way.

(18) *Variable Binding: Absolute Arguments > EXT*

- a. Mau [_{voip} na-yolo-ang [_s sola-na *pro*] [_o iCicci'] [_D pallukis **nasang**]],
 though 3ERG-show-APPL friend-3GEN her NAME painter every
 ‘Though her_{i,j} friend showed [–FIN] every_i painter Chichi’,
 b. Mau [_{voip} na-solangang [_s kindo'-na *pro*] [_o sanaeke **nasang**]],
 though 3ERG-accompany mom-3GEN her kid every
 ‘Though her_{i,j} mom accompanied [–FIN] every_i kid,’

The force of these facts is to suggest that the stable vsOD order masks a pattern of covert movement to a low subject position at edge of the extended VP: one that skips

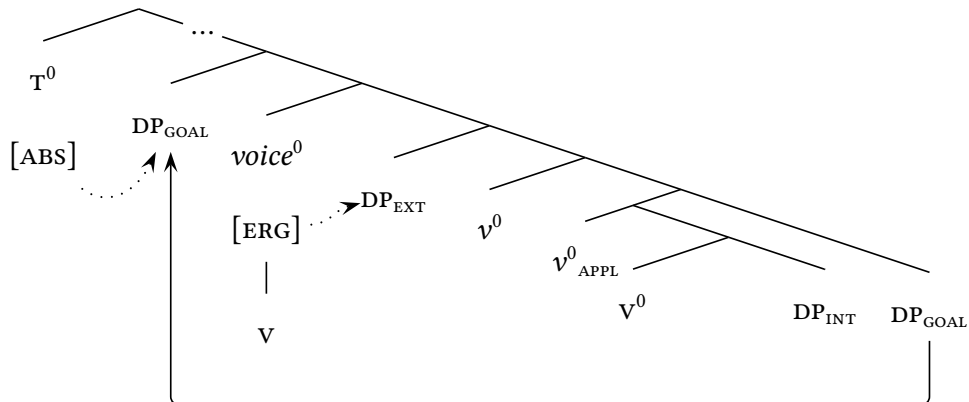
the EXT and attract the highest argument beneath it to SPEC,voiceP. When the verb is transitive, this step targets the INT (19a); when the verb is ditransitive, it targets the GOAL (19b). These steps consistently impute the absolutive DP with privilege in the systems of binding and coreference and carry it to a position that feeds interaction with T^0 .

(19) *The Low Subject Position: Attracts the Highest Argument Beneath the EXT*

- a. TRANSITIVE: $\left[\text{voiceP } \Theta \text{ v } \left[\text{vP s } \left[\text{vP o } \right] \right] \right]$
- b. DITRANSITIVE: $\left[\text{voiceP } \Theta \text{ v } \left[\text{vP s } \left[\text{applP } \left[\text{vP o } \right] \text{ D } \right] \right] \right]$

From this position, we can begin to draw links to the wider theory of ergativity. The low subject position systematically skips past the EXT to attract the highest argument in the voiceP, and this pattern correlates with a fact of agreement: voice^0 always agrees with the EXT. This type of “low” ergative agreement is familiar from many other systems where the absolutive DP interacts with T^0 (Bok-Bennema, 1991; Bittner & Hale, 1996a,b; Wiltschko, 2006; Coon *et al.*, 2014; Legate, 2014; Brown, 2016), and on the view that ϕ -agreement proceeds along the same pathways that assign Case (Raposo, 1987), it sets up an initial theory of attraction that is grounded in the logic of ACTIVITY (Chomsky, 2001). Taking voice^0 to assign ergative Case, more specifically, I propose that it also hosts an A-probe that attracts the highest Caseless DP. We thus arrive at the syntax in (20).

(20) *Ditransitives: GOAL > Low Subject Position for Case*



We thus emerge from our initial foray into the ditransitive with a theory that posits two basic layers of syntax to the Mandar clause: a TP-level system that assigns the highest source of abstract Case and a *voiceP*-level system that determines the identity of the DP that will receive it—in the transitive, the INT, and in the ditransitive, the GOAL. This is the same type of syntax that has been proposed for Selayarese, another language of the South Sulawesi Subfamily (Finer, 1997, 1999; Béjar, 1999), and it is similar to the general theory of Western Austronesian clause structure advanced by Guilfoyle *et al.* 1992: one that has led to real insight into the core languages of their investigation (Tagalog, Cebuano, Malay, Indonesian, and Malagasy) and since been productively extended across the region to many more (Aldridge, 2004, 2008, 2011, 2016; Nomoto, 2013, 2015; Legate, 2014; Erlewine, 2018; Erlewine & Lim, 2023; Erlewine & Sommerlot, To Appear; Nie, 2020; Ting, 2023).

2.3 Priority Parcels

On this analysis, the patterns of movement and agreement that we have seen so far are closely bound up with the syntax of Case—and as such, we should expect them to operate along relatively consistent lines. But this system is derailed in an interesting way when the ditransitive INT is a pronoun of any type. The first sign of this shift is shown in example (21): when the ditransitive INT is a pronoun, it must control agreement on T^0 .

- (21) *Pronominal INT* → *Agreement Derailed*.....**x**
- | |
|--|
| [_{TP} [_{voiceP} na-yolo-ang a' [_{EXT} iKaco'] [_{INT} <i>pro</i>] [_{GOAL} iCicci']]]. |
| 3ERG-show-APPL 1ABS NAME me NAME |
| ‘Kacho’ showed me to Chichi.’ |

This morphological shift then triggers a string of changes in the systems of movement and binding. When we set up the configuration that forces overt movement of the absolutive DP, to begin, we get the result in (22a): the ditransitive GOAL must stay in the *voiceP*. It is ungrammatical for the GOAL to move overtly in its usual way (22b).

(22) *Pronominal INT* → *Low GOAL*

- a. $[\text{TP } \text{Yari } \mathbf{a'} \quad [\text{voiceP } ___ \text{na-yolo-ang} \quad [\text{s iKaco'}] [\text{o } \textit{pro}] [\text{D iCicci'}]]]$.
 DID 1ABS 3ERG-show-APPL NAME me NAME
 ‘Kacho’ DID show me to Chichi.’
- b. $[\text{TP } * \text{Yari } \mathbf{a'} \quad [\text{voiceP } [\text{D iCicci'}] \text{na-yolo-ang} \quad [\text{s iKaco'}] [\text{o } \textit{pro}] ___]]$.
 DID 1ABS NAME 3ERG-show-APPL NAME me
 INTENDED ‘Kacho’ DID show me to Chichi.’

This suspension of Absolutive Preposing is then mirrored by a shift in variable binding. In the finite clauses that contain absolutive agreement, the quantifier *nasang* undergoes a type of subextraction: it raises out of its associate to cluster with τ^0 (Brodkin 2025e; across the subfamily see Basri 2003; Jukes 2006). Example (23) shows the effect in a finite VSOD clause, where *nasang* originates in the INT: in that context, it moves from its usual postnominal position to a landing site that falls just before absolutive agreement.

(23) *Finite Clauses: Nasang Subextracts*

- $[\text{TP } [\text{voiceP } \text{Na-yolo-ang} \quad \mathbf{\text{nasang } \mathbf{a'}} \quad [\text{s iKaco'}] [\text{o sola-na } ___] [\text{D } \textit{pro}]]]$.
 3ERG-show-APPL every 1ABS NAME pal-3GEN *t* me
 ‘Kacho’ showed me every one of his friends.’

This type of subextraction has no effect on the system of variable binding, and as a result, we see the same possibilities of coreference across finite and non-finite clauses. In finite ditransitive clauses where the INT is a DP, then, the GOAL can still bind into the EXT (24a), just as if it covertly raised. The INT, in turn, cannot (24b)—just as if it stayed low.

(24) *Variable Binding in Finite Clauses: GOAL > EXT > INT*

- a. $[\text{TP } \text{Na-yolo-ang} \quad \mathbf{\text{nasang } \mathbf{i}} \quad [\text{s kindo'-na } \textit{pro}] [\text{o seni}] [\text{D sanaeke } ___]]$.
 3ERG-show-APPL every 3ABS mom-3GEN her art kid *t*_{nasang}
 ‘Her_{*i,j*} mom showed every_{*i*} kid some art.’
- b. $[\text{TP } \text{Na-yolo-ang} \quad \mathbf{\text{nasang } \mathbf{a'}} \quad [\text{s kindo'-na } \textit{pro}] [\text{o sanaeke } ___] [\text{D } \textit{pro}]]]$.
 3ERG-show-APPL every 3ABS mom-3GEN her kid *t*_{nasang} me
 ‘Her_{*i,j*} mom showed me every_{*i*} kid.’

When the INT is a pronoun, however, the facts reverse. The GOAL loses the ability to bind into the EXT (25a), as if it had ceased to move to SPEC, *voiceP*. The INT, in turn, gains the ability to bind into the EXT (25b)—as if it had moved into that position instead.

(25) *Variable Binding + Pronominal INT: INT > EXT > GOAL*

- a. [TP Na-yolo-ang **nasang** a' [s kindo'-na *pro*] [o *pro*] [D sanaeke ____]].
 3ERG-show-APPL every 1ABS mom-3GEN her me kid *t_{nasang}*
 'Her **_{i,j}* mom showed me to every_{*i*} kid.'
- b. [TP Na-yolo-ang **nasang** i [s kindo'-na *pro*] [o *pro* ____] [D dottor]].
 3ERG-show-APPL every 3ABS mom-3GEN her her *t_{nasang}* doctor
 'Her_{*i,j*} mom showed the doctor every_{*i*} one of them.'

We can now go on to note the very same realignment in the domain of Condition C. Within the system of pronominal coreference, Mandarin imposes a second restriction that tracks the facts of c-command: pronouns cannot c-command coreferential R-expressions (Brodkin, 2022). In the typical ditransitives of the language, this restriction delivers a classical network of Condition C effects (Reinhart, 1983). When the GOAL moves to the low subject position, to begin, it gains the ability to contain R-expressions coindexed with a pronominal EXT (26a). In the same vein, it becomes ungrammatical for the EXT to contain R-expressions coindexed with a pronominal GOAL (26b).

(26) *Condition C: $GOAL > EXT$*

- a. [TP Na-yolo-ang i [s *pro*] [o seni] [D kindo'-na [_{CP} iKaco' na iCicci']]]].
 3ERG-show-APPL 1ABS she art mom-3GEN NAME and NAME
 'She_i showed Kacho' and Chichi'_i's mom some art.'
- b. [TP Na-yolo-ang i [s kindo'-na [_{CP} iKaco' na iCicci']]] [o seni] [D *pro*]].
 3ERG-show-APPL 1ABS mom-3GEN NAME and NAME art her
 'Kacho' and Chichi'_i's mom showed her_{*i} some art.'

Within the same configuration, the same constraints show that the INT remains low. We can see the most important side of this system in contexts where the INT is a pronoun

that fails to raise to the low subject position: for instance, in the clauses where the GOAL is a pronoun as well. In this configuration, absolutive agreement must target the GOAL—and in that context, it is possible for the INT to corefer with an R-expression in the EXT (27).

(27) *Condition C: EXT > INT*

$$\begin{array}{ccccccc} & & & & & & \downarrow \\ & & & & & & \vdots \\ [\text{TP Na-yolo-ang} & \text{a'} & [\text{s kindo'-na} & [\text{\phi_P iKaco' na iCicci'}]] & [\text{o pro}] & [\text{D pro}]] & \\ & \text{3ERG-show-APPL 1ABS} & \text{mom-3GEN} & \text{NAME and NAME} & \text{her} & \text{me} & \end{array}$$

‘Kacho’ and Chichi’_i’s mom showed her_i to me.’

The facts are reversed when the GOAL is a DP and the INT a pronoun. In that context, it is impossible for the GOAL to host R-expressions coindexed with the EXT (28a). In the same vein, it is impossible for the EXT to host R-expressions coindexed with the INT (28b).

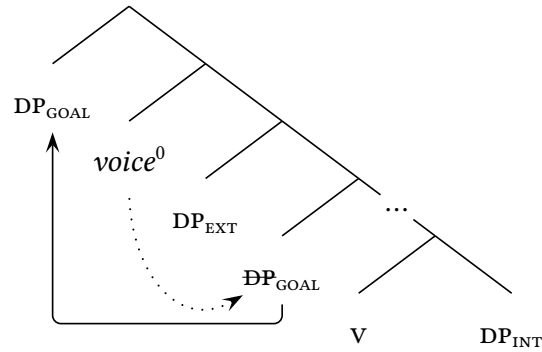
(28) *Pronominal INT: INT > EXT > GOAL*

- $$\begin{array}{ccccccc} & & & & & & \downarrow \\ & & & & & & \vdots \\ \text{a. } [\text{TP Na-yolo-ang} & \text{a'} & [\text{s pro}] & [\text{o pro}] & [\text{D kindo'-na} & [\text{\phi_P iKaco' na iCicci'}]] & \\ & \text{3ERG-show-APPL 3ABS} & \text{she} & \text{me} & \text{mom-3GEN} & \text{NAME and NAME} & \\ & & & & & & \vdots \\ & & & & & & \downarrow \\ \text{b. } [\text{TP Na-yolo-ang} & \text{i} & [\text{s kindo'-na} & [\text{\phi_P iKaco' na iCicci'}]] & [\text{o pro}] & [\text{D dottor}]] & \\ & \text{3ERG-show-APPL 1ABS} & \text{mom-3GEN} & \text{NAME \& NAME} & \text{her} & \text{doctor} & \end{array}$$
- ‘She*_i showed me to Kacho’ and Chichi’_i’s mom.’
- ‘Kacho’ and Chichi’_i’s mom showed her*_i to the doctor.’

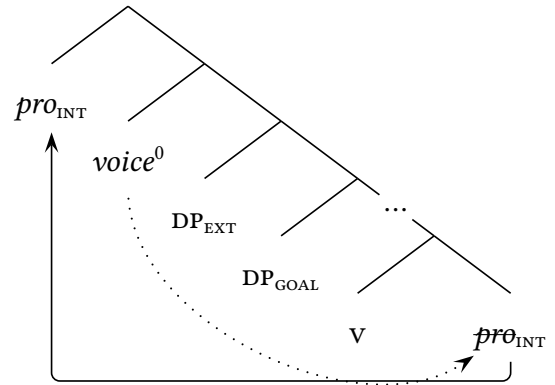
The combined force of these pieces is to suggest a system with the following shape. In all DP-DP ditransitives in Mandar, the GOAL is base-generated above the INT in a rightward specifier of *appl*⁰. When the GOAL and INT are both pronouns or both DPs, the low subject position canonically attracts the Caseless GOAL to SPEC,voiceP: an A-position that feeds Case-licensing by τ^0 (29a). When the GOAL is a DP and the INT is a pronoun, however, this step is derailed—and *voice*⁰ skips over the GOAL to attract the INT instead (29b). I will refer to this as a PRIORITY EFFECT.

(29) *The Syntax of the Mandar Ditransitive*

a. *The Regular Configuration*



b. *The Priority Effect*



The immediate force of this conclusion is to reveal a case of GENERALIZED INVERSION, in the terminology of [Bailyn 2004](#): there is a single position that triggers attraction, well-integrated with the wider A-syntax, which seems able to skip past its usual targets to attract non-canonical goals from positions beneath that point. In this respect, it falls together with many further cases of this shape—from locative inversion in English ([Collins 1996](#)) to analogous steps of A-attraction that can skip subjects to target objects in Japanese ([Miyagawa, 2001](#)) and a wider range of elements in Russian ([Bailyn, 2004](#)). But unlike these cases, it is specifically conditioned by the relative shapes of the GOAL and the INT—falling together in this way with a range of parallel effects known from the literature on AGREE. We thus advance to the next stage of our investigation with these three questions in hand:

(30) *The Guiding Questions of the Investigation*

1. What allows the A-syntax to forego strict locality and skip its usual targets?
2. What allows derivations of this type to escape the ensuing problems of Case?
3. What makes certain goals into priority parcels that are favored for MOVE?

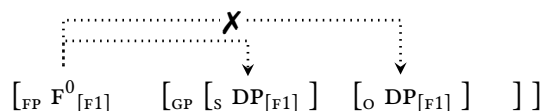
3 Best-Match Attraction

We can begin the next stage of our investigation from the matter of **PRIORITY**: how might the A-syntax compare among multiple targets for **MOVE**, rank them along scales of preference, and drive the selective pattern of movement above? To resolve this question, we will turn to the parallel effects that emerge around ϕ -agreement and leverage specific lines of progress from that literature to articulate a revised theory of **MOVE**. This is one on which **MOVE** must be prefigured by an operation that links attracting heads with all licit goals in their search space—setting up the context for a pattern of **BEST-MATCH ATTRACTION** that emerges in the contexts that loosen the usual rules of A-locality.

3.1 The Operation Link

Our work begins with the theory of probing: the mechanism that links heads with their goals at the derivational stage before **MOVE** and **AGREE**. The dependencies of the A-syntax, like all systems in language, show a locality profile with a finely relativized shape (Rizzi, 1990): they freely cross over many types of constituents, from adjuncts and $\bar{A}$ -elements to the heads that define locality domains for head-movement, but in the general case, they do not skip intervening **DPS**. To capture this pattern in derivational terms, Chomsky 2001 proposes that this locality profiles is grounded in the mechanism of searching itself: **MOVE** and **AGREE** are prefigured by a type of **PROBING** that searches through the c-command domain of its driving head, proceeds until it hits a matching goal, and then stops (31).

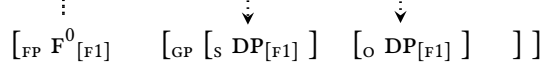
(31) *Agreement: Classical Formulation*



In the realm of ϕ -agreement, however, there are many patterns to suggest that the

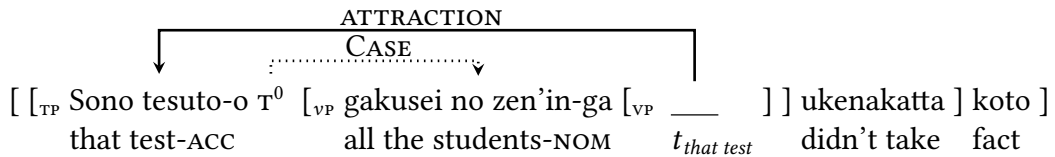
system of probing must be able to see past the highest licit targets in its search domain. This view emerges from several interconnected effects: (i) cases where AGREE copies back the same feature from multiple targets at once, yielding patterns of omnivorous agreement (Nevins, 2011), (ii) cases where AGREE for a wider category of features, like person, copies back subfeatures from multiple goals (Deal, 2015; Coon & Keine, 2021), and (iii) cases where AGREE seems to compare among multiple goals and copy back the full feature bundle of one or the other (Coon & Bale, 2014; Oxford, 2014, 2019). These effects suggest that ϕ -agreement must emerge from the joint work of two distinct mechanisms: an operation of PROBING that links heads with multiple different goals, along the lines in (32), and an operation of AGREE that compares these possible targets and selects among them as it copies ϕ -features back (Béjar & Rezac, 2003, 2009; Deal, 2015; Coon & Keine, 2021).

(32) *Revision: Heads Can Access Multiple Goals*



In the domain of movement, patterns of inversion then force the same analytical step. In Japanese, for instance, Miyagawa 2001 observes that the movement-driving probe on τ^0 seems able to skip past the subject and attract the object to SPEC,TP (33). To force this step, τ^0 must be allowed to interact with the object—but to capture the distribution of nominative Case, it must be allowed to agree with the subject as well. Miyagawa 2001 thus proposes that MOVE must also be prefigured by a separate operation of probing with the shape in (32) above: one that connects the driving head with multiple possible goals.

(33) *Miyagawa 2001: Multiple Agree in Japanese*



‘The fact that all the students didn’t take the test.’

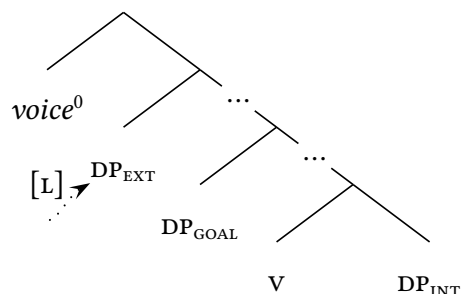
(34) Hedding 2022: Comparison between Goals in the $\bar{A}$ -Domain

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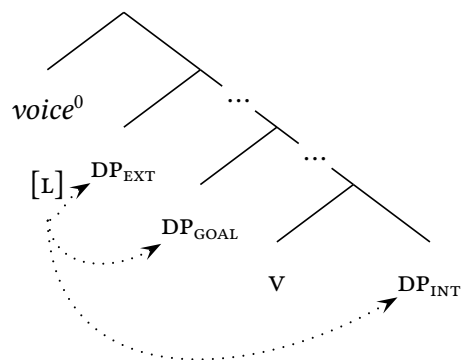
become impossible, I assume that the operation simply fails (Preminger, 2011)—putting an end to LINK and passing on its connections to the next derivational stage.

(35) *The Operation Link*

a. *First Step*



b. *Eventual Result*



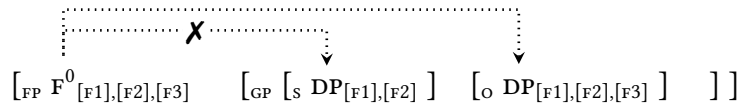
3.2 Best-Match Effects

From this position, we can now lay the foundations for the theory of PRIORITY A-attraction. In the literature on AGREE, the standard account of the parallel effects is grounded in the notion of ECONOMY: the derivational pressure to check features in a maximally efficient way. The account flows from three interlocking hypotheses. The first holds that multiple features on syntactic heads can be accessed at the same time, yielding a parallel calculus of feature-checking (Chomsky, 1995; Pesetsky & Torrego, 2001; Longenbaugh, 2019). The second hypothesis holds that heads must check as many features as they can once they begin to interact with a single goal: if it carries features that drive MOVE and AGREE, for instance, it must check both with a single goal (the FREE RIDER CONDITION of Chomsky 1995; Bruening 2001; Rezac 2013). In the cases where heads make contact with multiple goals, at last, the third hypothesis holds that the choice among them must be guided by a parallel constraint: one that favors the goals that satisfy the maximum number of features at once (the pressure for MULTITASKING: Pesetsky & Torrego 2001; Van Urk & Richards

2015; Van Urk 2015; Newman 2024).

The combined weight of these ingredients is to allow the derivation to select among multiple possible goals in response to two factors: (i) the featural requirements of heads and (ii) the featural profiles of goals. Patterns of agreement in person, for instance, are routinely taken to be driven by a range of separate features on heads: (Béjar & Rezac, 2009), for instance, propose that it implicates a series of *segments*, or sub-probes, that search independently for the hierarchically nested features that make up the category of PERSON (e.g., PERSON, PARTICIPANT, and SPEAKER: Harley & Ritter 2002). When a sub-probe of this type makes contact with a goal, they argue, FREE RIDER CONDITION forces it to copy back as many features as it possibly can (and see Deal 2015; Coon & Keine 2021 for similar views). When probes of this shape make contact with multiple goals at once, in turn, Coon & Bale 2014 and Oxford 2014, 2019 argue for a second type of effect: one on which the target for AGREE is directly determined by the requirement for Multitasking. The shape of this second effect is shown in diagram (36): when a head with features F1-F2-F3 is linked with two goals and one satisfies F1-F2 but the other satisfies F1-F2-F3, it is forced to AGREE with the second. I will refer to this pattern as a BEST-MATCH EFFECT.

(36) *Agreement: Best-Match Effects*



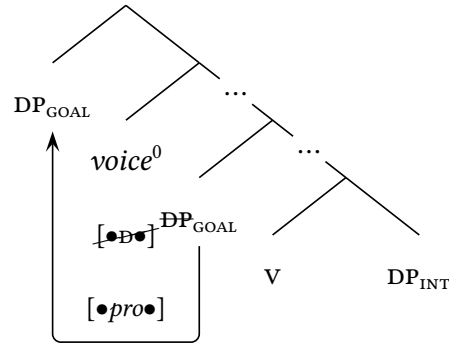
We now have a path to derive the priority effect. In the Mandarin *voice_P*, I propose that *voice⁰* carries two features: one that forces attraction of DPs and one that forces attraction of pronouns. Denoting these features as $[\bullet D \bullet]$ and $[\bullet pro \bullet]$, we can organize them into a hierarchy: $[pro]$ entails $[D]$, such that any element that satisfies $[\bullet pro \bullet]$ will satisfy $[\bullet D \bullet]$.

In this configuration, we can leverage the logic of economy to force our result. When *voice⁰* triggers LINK and makes contact with the ditransitive GOAL and INT, it engages in

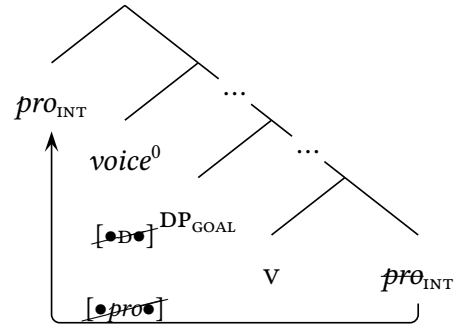
a calculus of the following shape. To satisfy $[\bullet D \bullet]$, it will always suffice to attract either DP. When the GOAL and the INT are both DPs, however, there will be no way to satisfy $[\bullet pro \bullet]$. As a result, the syntax defaults to the pattern of attraction in (37a): one on which $voice^0$ draws up the GOAL in response to the pressure for strict locality in the A-syntax. But when the INT is a pronoun, a second possibility emerges: if the constraints on strict locality were relaxed, both $[\bullet D \bullet]$ and $[\bullet pro \bullet]$ could be checked by attracting the INT. In contexts of priority, I propose this is exactly what occurs: the A-syntax manages to evade these constraints and forego the GOAL to draw up the INT instead (37b). The result is a pattern of attraction that follows the logic of BEST MATCH Coon & Bale 2014; Oxford 2014, 2019: in the terminology of Hedding 2022, 2024, a type of BEST-MATCH ATTRACTION.

(37) *Priority Movement via Economy: Derivation*

a. *Canonical Attraction*



b. *Priority Attraction*



We can thus begin to understand how the priority effect might fit into a general theory of attraction. In the calculus of economy that follows LINK, the derivation must systematically weigh the features of the driving head against those of all possible goals. In the A-syntax, the typical result is movement of the closest DP: a pattern forced by the usual constraints on A-locality. But under a network of conditions that loosen those constraints and manage the consequences for Case—conditions that must soon be understood—the pressure for Multitasking can force the priority effect.

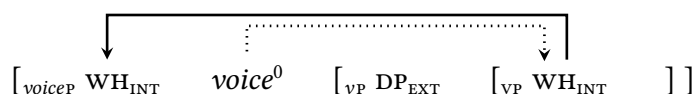
4 Locality at the Edge

With this much in place, we can shift to the second guiding question of our investigation: within the system of PRIORITY, what allows the usual rules of A-locality to be relaxed? I propose that the answer lies in a link to position. The steps of non-local movement in this system all target the edge of the extended VP, and this is a position that [Chomsky 2001](#) takes to play a central role in the $\bar{A}$ -domain: one that defines a stopover point for $\bar{A}$ -extraction evinced by patterns of WH-quantifier stranding ([Barbiers, 2002](#); [Koopman, 2010](#); [Henry, 2012](#); [Doliana, 2022](#)), morphological extraction-marking ([Bruening, 2001](#); [Bennett et al., 2012](#)) and partial spell-out ([Van Urk, 2018](#)), and many further effects ([Fox, 1999](#); [Nissenbaum, 2000](#)). The task of this section is thus to make sense of this fact—and to build a theory that allows the rules of A-locality to be loosened at the edge.

4.1 The $\bar{A}$ Connection

[Chomsky 2001](#) proposes that the edge of the extended VP acquires its importance in the $\bar{A}$ -domain from the fact that it defines a cyclic domain for syntactic computation: in his terminology, a *phase*. Building from this hypothesis, [Chomsky 2008](#) argues that the head at the edge of the extended VP must be endowed with a second type of movement-driving feature: one that specifically targets the class of elements that must be removed from cyclic domains for the derivation to converge. It is this second type of feature, he argues, that drives $\bar{A}$ -attraction to the edge (38)

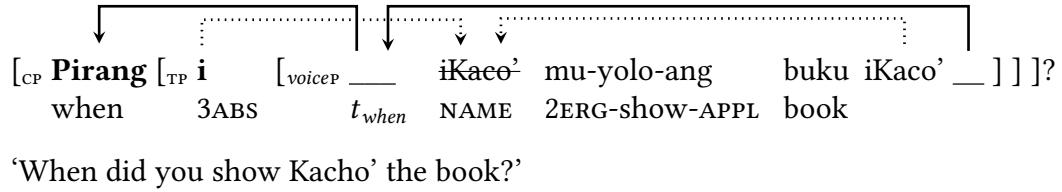
(38) *Phase Edge: Non-Local Attraction*



[Chomsky 2008](#) argues that the EDGE FEATURES in this system belong to the $\bar{A}$ -domain:

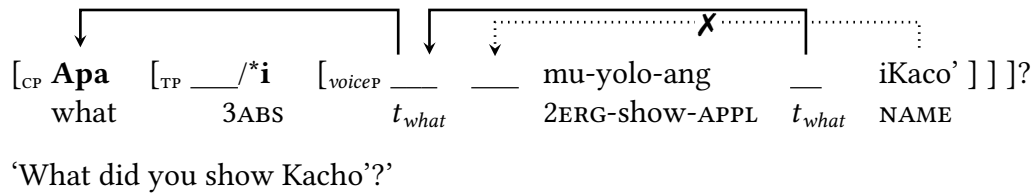
they trigger steps of movement that canonically show the standard $\bar{A}$ -properties (lacking category restrictions, skipping intervening DPs, licensing parasitic gaps, and preferentially reconstructing) and they place their targets in positions that are invisible to the A-syntax (failing to intervene for ϕ -agreement, Case-assignment, and higher steps of A-movement). In the general case, this must be correct: in Mandar, for instance, WH-movement must pass through this edge (Brodkin, 2025d), and this step typically has no affect on the connection between the absolutive DP in SPEC, *voiceP* and T^0 . When adjunct WH-phrases raise in this way, then, ditransitive GOALS still AGREE with T^0 (39).

(39) *Attraction to the Edge: Separate from the A-Syntax*



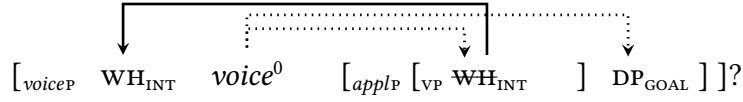
Despite this fact, it is clear that this position can license interactions of a second type: the steps of movement forced by EDGE FEATURES often seem to derail independent A-movements to the same position (Van Urk, 2015; Holmberg *et al.*, 2019; Newman, 2024). We can see this type of interference in the Mandar *voiceP* in the contexts where WH-phrases take the position of the ditransitive INT. In that context, Brodkin 2025d shows, the low subject position ceases to attract the GOAL: that DP loses its privileges of binding, never undergoes Absolutive Preposing, and cannot AGREE with T^0 (40).

(40) *Certain Types of Movement to the Edge: Interaction*



To capture this second type of effect, [Van Urk 2015](#) proposes that a particular type of Multitasking is at play: when the phase head carries triggers for A-movement ($[\bullet D \bullet]$) and edge features that drive $\bar{A}$ -extraction ($[\bullet x \bullet]$), the syntax seeks to check them both with a single goal. As a result, the derivation can forego the usual steps of A-movement to force a type of attraction that falls between A and $\bar{A}$: one that derails the A-syntax because it checks A-features but skips DPs because it is driven by $\bar{A}$ -features (41).

(41) *Special Movement to the Edge: Multitasking with A'*



The result is a system that draws a particular link from locality to height to $\bar{A}$ -attraction:

- (i) the head that defines the phase edge has the ability to drive special types of attraction,
- (ii) those effects reflect the work of edge features, which license non-local movement,
- (iii) edge features operate in the $\bar{A}$ -domain, prioritizing $\bar{A}$ -elements like WH -phrases, and
- (iv) it is these $\bar{A}$ -edge features that lie behind all apparent steps of non-local A-movement: apparent non-local A-movement always implicates mixed A- and $\bar{A}$ -attraction to the edge.

4.2 The Theory of Visibility

To evaluate this link from loose locality to $\bar{A}$ -interference, we can begin by building a set of predictions about what it might mean for steps of movements and their associated landing sites to fall between A and $\bar{A}$. To this end, it will be useful to draw a distinction that has largely passed under the radar in prior work on the divide: one that separates the internal properties of movements themselves from the ways that their landing sites are treated by the external systems of the A-syntax. This cut is sketched in (42).

(42) *The A- $\bar{A}$ Divide: Two Parts*

- a. PROPERTIES OF MOVEMENT: *category restrictions, strict locality, reconstruction*
- b. PROPERTIES OF POSITIONS: *feeding Case-assignment; ϕ -agreement; A-movement*

This distinction is useful for the way it allows us to contrast our priority effects with a second class of movements that share two properties of type (42a): namely, those that show the locality profile of $\bar{A}$ -attraction but the binding profile of A-movement. The most notable operations of this type are those traditionally grouped under the label of A-scrambling, familiar from Germanic (Vanden Wyngaerd, 1989; Jonas & Bobaljik, 1993; Collins & Thráinsson, 1993; Merchant, 1996; Grewendorf & Sabel, 1999), Hindi (Mahajan, 1989), Japanese (Saito, 1992; Miyagawa, 1997), and many other languages (Frank *et al.*, 1996; McGinnis, 1998; Ko, 2014; Gong, 2023), as well as the types of movement that seem to underlie clitic doubling in languages like Rioplatense Spanish (Suñer, 1988), Romanian (Dobrovie-Sorin, 1994), Greek (Alexiadou & Anagnostopoulou, 1997; Angelopoulos, 2019), Bulgarian (Harizanov, 2014), and Amharic (Kramer, 2014). Like priority attraction, all of these operations seem able to draw DPs across higher nominal arguments, and all of them seem to license various types of binding into the elements they cross. The following examples illustrate this effect in Rioplatense Spanish: when the INT is doubled by a clitic, it undergoes a type of movement above the EXT that allows it to bind into that DP.

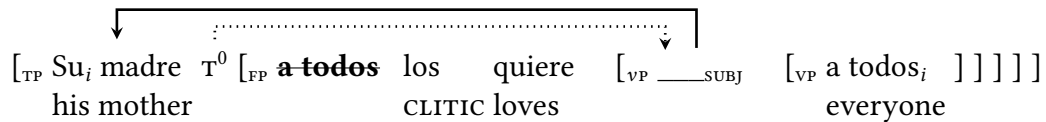
(43) *Second Class of Movements: $\bar{A}$ for Locality, A for Binding*

- a. Su_{*i} madre quiere a todos_i.
his mother loves everyone
'His_{i,j} mother loves everyone_i. Suñer 1988, 68b

- b. $[\text{TP } Su_i \text{ madre } [\text{EP } a \text{ todos } \textbf{los} \text{ quiere } [\text{VP } su_i \text{ madre } [\text{VP } a \text{ todos}_i]]]]$.
his mother CLITIC loves everyone
'His_{i,j} mother loves everyone_i. Suñer 1988, 69a

The network of operations in this second class are valuable for the ways in which they seem to contrast with our priority effects with respect to the second property above: the ways in which they interact with the higher systems of the A-syntax. Across systems of A-scrambling and clitic doubling, it has been consistently observed that steps like (43b), which place INTS and GOALS above the EXT, have no effect on the syntax of subjecthood. When these arguments seem to undergo A-movement above the EXT for the purposes of binding, more specifically, they fail to intervene for higher steps of AGREE and ATTRACT. This fact can be seen neatly in Spanish, where subjects typically agree with T^0 and raise to SPEC,TP (Goodall, 2001; Suñer, 2003; Camacho, 2006; Gutiérrez-Bravo, 2007; Sheehan, 2016): in that language, both processes skip the INT in the apparent A-position in (44).

(44) *Second Class of Movements: Landing Sites Invisible to the A-Syntax*



‘His_{*i} mother loves everyone.

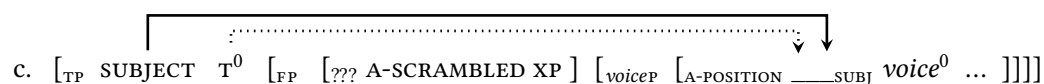
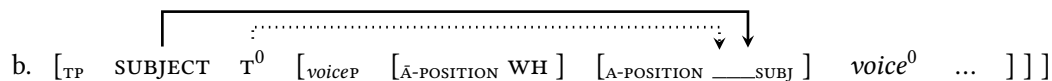
Suñer 1988, 69a

There is a natural way to understand these effects, and it is one that emerges from the literature on feeding relationships between different types of MOVE. It has long been observed that there is a restriction on the types of positions that can launch A-movement (Chomsky, 1973; May, 1979): descriptively speaking, movement into an A-position must be launched from an A-position, rather than an adjunct position or a landing site of the $\bar{A}$ -syntax (45a). This restriction, known as the BAN ON IMPROPER MOVEMENT, has typically been invoked to explain patterns of the shape in (45b): patterns of A-attraction will systematically look past $\bar{A}$ -elements in $\bar{A}$ -positions, like WH-phrases at the edge of the *voiceP*. But in a study of A-scrambling in German, Müller & Sternefeld 1993, 1996 propose that it also underlies invisibility effect in (45c): the A-syntax must also ignore the elements that

occupy the landing sites of A-scrambling, as if they occupied positions that formed illicit launching sites for later A-movements as well (and see also [Abels 2007](#) for a similar view).

(45) *The Ban on Improper Movement*

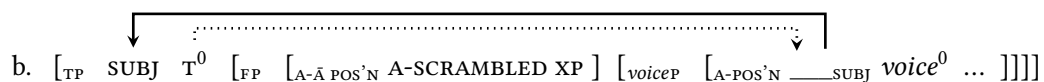
- a. DEFINITION: Movement into A-positions must be launched from A-positions.



To capture this restriction, [Abels 2007](#) proposes that the constraint beneath the Ban on Improper Movement is one that is finely relativized to a richer series of distinctions that fall between the endpoints of A and $\bar{\text{A}}$: pure A-movements cannot be fed by A-scrambling, and A-scrambling cannot be fed by pure $\bar{\text{A}}$ -operations like, for instance, WH-movement. If we accept the hypothesis that movements and positions can be simultaneously A and $\bar{\text{A}}$, it then seems natural to recast the key restriction along the following lines: A-scrambling cannot feed regular A-movement because it is a mixed A- $\bar{\text{A}}$ operation ([Webelhuth, 1989b](#)). The ensuing constraint and derivational consequence are presented below in (46).

(46) *The Ban on Improper Movement: Revised*

- a. ADDENDUM: Movement into A-positions cannot proceed from A- $\bar{\text{A}}$ -positions.

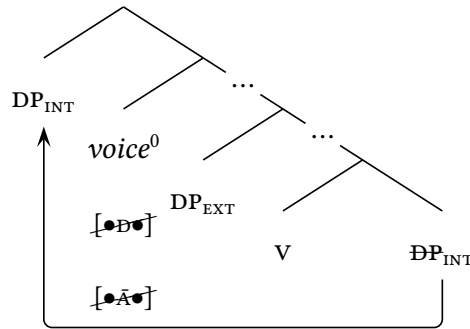


Formally speaking, I propose that this analysis plays out along the following lines. To derive the facts of binding, I propose that these movements are driven by heads that carry the feature $[\bullet\text{D}\bullet]$: the ordinary driver of A-attraction and one that enforces a preference against reconstruction in the calculus of binding and coreference. To capture the facts of

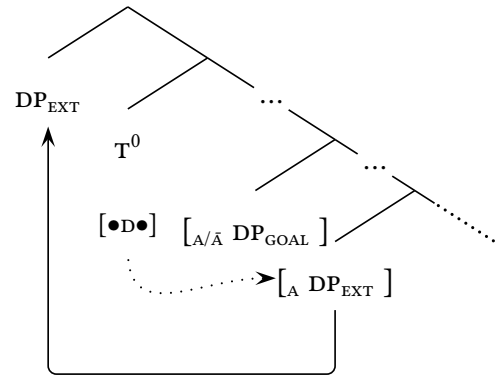
locality, however, these heads must also host an $\bar{A}$ -feature that drives non-local attraction: either an edge feature or a second type of feature that drives A-scrambling, like $[\bullet\Sigma\bullet]$. When these features cooccur, the system of economy will force movement-driving heads to draw up a single target, yielding non-local steps of attraction like (47a). And as these steps are driven by the joint work of A- and $\bar{A}$ -features, we might then imagine—following the featural definition of A- and $\bar{A}$ -positions in Van Urk 2015—that they will place their targets in A- $\bar{A}$ -positions as well. As a result, I propose that they will be invisible to LINK as it builds the arteries of the higher A-syntax—and thus invisible for A-attraction (47b).

(47) *Mixed A- $\bar{A}$ Positions: Towards a Theory*

a. *Scrambling: A- $\bar{A}$ Mixing*



b. *Mixed Positions: Invisible*



4.3 Priority Movement and the High Subject Position

This footwork is useful for the fact that it builds a link to a second layer of the Mandarin clause: the higher syntax of subjecthood. Above the low subject position, Brodtkin 2025c establishes that there is a second and higher subject position projected in the middle field: one that also triggers movement that is canonically covert. Under a fine network of circumstances, however, it is possible to force this step to be overt—in that context, we will see that our patterns of priority feed the A-syntax in a regular way.

The case begins from the syntax of a class of consistently adnominal quantifiers, first

documented and analyzed by Brodtkin 2025c. This class includes elements of two types: weak quantifiers like *mai'di* “many” and *sicco* “few” (48a) and strong quantifiers like *inggannanna* “every” and *ianasanna* “each” (48b). All of these elements appear in prenominal positions, on a par with the demonstratives and determiners of the language, and Brodtkin 2025c thus proposes that they spell out quantificational heads within the extended NP.

(48) *A Second Class of Quantifiers*

- a. [_{QP} Mai'di anjoro], [_{QP} sicco' anjoro]
 many coconut few coconut
 ‘Many coconuts, a few coconuts.’
- b. [_{QP} Inggannanna bonde], [_{QP} ianasanna batu bonde]
 all sand each grain sand
 ‘All the sand, each grain of sand’

These QPs are useful because they move in a fashion that is systematically overt. When they take the positions of absolutive DPs, then, they never surface in the usual postverbal positions of argument DPs. When a strong QP takes the position of a transitive INT in a non-finite clause, rather, it must be pronounced in the low subject position—even outside of the prosodic configuration that forces that pattern of spell-out for ordinary DPs.

(49) *Quantified Arguments: Move Overtly*

- Mau rua yari [_{voiceP} [_{INT} inggannanna paccoro] na-saka ____].
 though once DID all thief 3ERG-catch
 ‘Though once they DID catch [–FIN] all the thieves,’

This step of movement shows all the syntactic properties of the process that raises the absolutive DP. First, it targets the same linear position—the juncture between the lowest overt auxiliary and the verb. Second, it fills this position with a single QP—and thus when the INT and the GOAL are both quantified in the ditransitive, it applies to the GOAL and leaves the INT low (50a). Third, it ignores QPs that surface outside the positions of argument DPs: for instance, those adjoined to the *voiceP* or embedded within *PPs* (50b).

(50) *Quantified Arguments: Attracted by voice*⁰

- a. Mau rua [voiceP [GOAL ing. sola-u] u-carita-ngang [INT ing. fakta] _],
 though once all friend-1GEN 1ERG-tell-APPL all fact
 ‘Though once I told [–FIN] all my friends all the facts,’
 ↓ X X
- b. Mau byasa [voiceP ____ sita [PP sola ing. tau]] [AJT tuttu allo],
 though usually meet with all person every day
 ‘Though usually meeting [–FIN] with everyone every day,’

Fourth and finally, this process has a familiar impact on the systems of pronominal coreference and variable binding. To begin, it fails to reconstruct for Condition C—and thus when absolutive QPs raise in this way, they can always contain R-expressions that are coindexed with the EXT (51a). In the same vein, it introduces new possibilities for variable binding—and thus it is always possible for these QPs to bind variables in the EXT (51b).

(51) *Quantificational Phrases: Evidence for A-Movement*

- a. Mau rua [voiceP [INT ing. sola-na iAli] na-ita [EXT pro] ____].
 though once all friend-3GEN NAME 3ERG-see
 ‘Once *he*_{ij} saw [–FIN] all of Ali’s_i friends.’
 ↓
- b. Mau byasa [voiceP [INT ian. kindo’] na-ita [EXT sanaeke-na pro] ____].
 though usually each mom 3ERG-see child-3GEN her
 ‘Though usually *her*_{ij} kid sees [–FIN] each mom_i.’
 ↓

Brodkin 2025c thus argues that absolutive QPs are drawn to the low subject position by the same syntax that attracts regular absolutive DPs. What separates these two steps of movement is a purely surface-level fact: QPs must be spelled out in the highest positions they pass through. This understanding will be essential to our case for the higher syntax of subjecthood and the position of the priority effect, and it is sketched in diagram (52).

(52) *An Asymmetry in Spell-Out*

- a. A-MOVEMENT OF DPs = COVERT:
$$[_{voiceP} \overline{DP}_{ABS} \text{ voice}^0 [_{VP} DP_{ERG} [_{VP} V DP_{ABS}]]]$$
- b. A-MOVEMENT OF QPs = OVERT:
$$[_{voiceP} QP_{ABS} \text{ voice}^0 [_{VP} DP_{ERG} [_{VP} V QP_{ABS}]]]$$

For our purposes, these QPs are useful because they move with priority as well. In the ditransitive *voiceP*s where the GOAL is a regular DP, then, both weak and strong QPs are exceptionally attracted to SPEC,*voiceP* from the position of the INT.

(53) *Quantified Arguments: Priority Movement*

- a. Mau $[_{voiceP} [_{INT} \text{ mai'di fakta }] \text{ u-yolo-ang } \text{ — } [_{GOAL} \text{ sola-u }]]$,
 though many fact 1ERG-show-APPL friend-1GEN
 ‘Though I showed [–FIN] my friends many facts,’
- b. Mau $[_{voiceP} [_{INT} \text{ ing. fakta }] \text{ u-yolo-ang } \text{ — } [_{GOAL} \text{ sola-u }]]$,
 though all fact 1ERG-show-APPL friend-1GEN
 ‘Though I showed [–FIN] my friends all the facts,’

This step of movement shows all the hallmarks of the priority effect. To begin, they force the usual changes to suggest that *voice*⁰ no longer attracts the GOAL. Under the conditions that force DPs to move overtly, to begin, they prevent the GOAL from surfacing in that position. In the same vein, they derail the patterns of binding that suggest that it moves covertly: for instance, they block binding from the GOAL into the EXT (54).

(54) *Priority Movement: Derails Binding from the GOAL into the EXT*

- a. Mau $[_{voiP} [_{O} \text{ mai'di fakta }] \text{ na-yolo-ang } [_{S} \text{ kindo'-na } \text{ pro }] [_{D} \text{ ana' nasang }]]$,
 though many fact 3ERG-show-APPL mom-3GEN her kid every
 ‘Though her_{*i,j} mom showed [–FIN] every_i kid many facts,’
- b. Mau $[_{voiP} [_{O} \text{ ing. fakta }] \text{ na-yolo-ang } [_{S} \text{ kindo'-na } \text{ pro }] [_{D} \text{ ana' nasang }]]$,
 though all fact 3ERG-show-APPL mom-3GEN her kid every
 ‘Though her_{*i,j} mom showed [–FIN] every_i kid all the facts,’

When QPs raise in this way, in the same vein, they show all the hallmarks of undergoing A-movement themselves. Just like the QPs that raise regularly from the position of the GOAL, the QPs raised from the position of the ditransitive INT can contain R-expressions coindexed with the EXT (55a) and can bind variables in the EXT as well (55b).

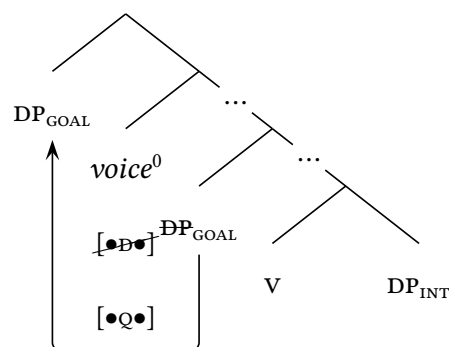
(55) *Priority Movement: New Binding Relationships with the EXT*

- a. Mau [_{voIP} [_o mai'di lukisan-na iCicci'] na-yolo-ang [_s *pro*] [_D iKaco']],
 though many friend-3GEN NAME 3ERG-show-APPL she NAME
 'Though she_i showed [−FIN] Kaco' many of Cicci's_i paintings,'
 b. Mau [_{voIP} [_o ian. lukisang] na-yolo-ang [_s pallukis-na *pro*] [_D iKaco']],
 though each painting 3ERG-show-APPL painter-3GEN its NAME
 'Though its_i painter showed [−FIN] Cicci' each_i painting,'

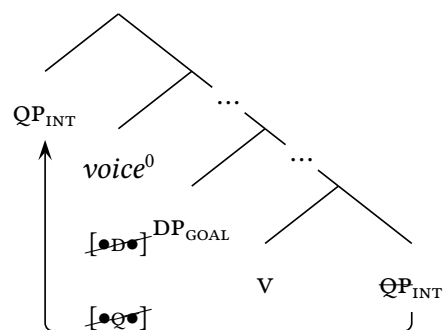
It thus seems clear that QPs must be drawn up to SPEC, *voiceP* through the same system of priority attraction as the pronouns of Sections 2-3: when they take the position of the ditransitive INT, some pressure for Multitasking must force them to be prioritized over regular DPs in the position of the GOAL. Formally, we can understand this effect to follow from the presence of a third type of feature on *voice*⁰: one that demands attraction of a QP. In the usual ditransitive *voiceP*s of the language, this is a feature that takes no effect and simply fails and disappears, on a par with the [•*pro*•] of Section 3 (56a). But in the *voiceP*s that host QPs, it drives priority attraction to SPEC, *voiceP* (56b).

(56) *Quantified Phrases: Priority Movement*

a. *Canonical Derivation*



b. *Priority Attraction*



With this much in place, we can now see how priority attraction feeds into the higher syntax of subjecthood. In finite clauses, the strong QPs in this system trigger the same patterns of agreement as the pronouns of Sections 2-3. When they raise normally from the position of the GOAL, they agree with T^0 (57a), but when they move with priority from the position of the INT, they trigger agreement in the same way (57b).

(57) *Priority Movement: Feeds Agreement with T^0*

- a. $\begin{array}{c} \downarrow \\ \text{[TP [D ing. sola-na] na-yolo-ang i [s iCicci'] [o lukisan-na]]}. \\ \text{all friend-3GEN 3ERG-show-APPL 3ABS NAME painting-3GEN} \end{array}$
‘Cicci’ showed all her friends her paintings.
- b. $\begin{array}{c} \downarrow \\ \text{[TP [o ing. lukisan-na] na-yolo-ang i [s iCicci'] [D sola-na]]}. \\ \text{all painting-3GEN 3ERG-show-APPL 3ABS NAME friend-3GEN} \end{array}$
‘Cicci’ showed her friends all her paintings.

This pattern of agreement then correlates with a shift in position: in finite clauses, these strong QPs visibly raise further into the middle field. This step places them in a position that precedes all overt auxiliaries, and it shows all the hallmarks of A-movement to a higher subject position: it strictly targets a single QP, only targets those QPs that raise to SPEC, *voiceP*, corresponds to a covert process that raises ordinary absolutive DPs, and alternates with a pattern of expletive insertion in the contexts where nothing can raise (Brodkin, 2025c). This process targets both the QPs that raise from the position of the GOAL (58a) and those that raise from the position of the INT (58b).

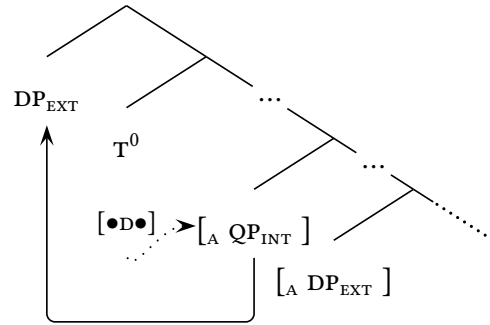
(58) *Priority Movement: Feeds Raising to SPEC, TP*

- a. $\begin{array}{c} \downarrow \\ \text{[TP [D ing. sola-na] rua i [voiP _ na-yolo-ang [o seni-na]]]}. \\ \text{all friend-3GEN once 3ABS 3ERG-show-APPL art-3GEN} \end{array}$
‘She once showed all her friends her art.
- b. $\begin{array}{c} \downarrow \\ \text{[TP [o ing. seni-na] rua i [voiP _ na-yolo-ang [D sola-na]]]}. \\ \text{all art-3GEN once 3ABS 3ERG-show-APPL friend-3GEN} \end{array}$
‘She once showed her friends all her art.

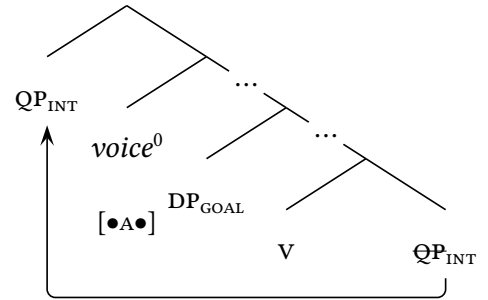
These facts establish a central contrast between priority attraction and the mechanisms that underlie A-scrambling and clitic doubling: priority attraction must feed AGREE with T^0 and raising to SPEC,TP. In this respect, it must define landing sites that are visible to the A-syntax—ones that can be accessed by LINK and fed into the calculus of MOVE and AGREE (59a). And on the theory of visibility outlined above, this conclusion leads to an important result: if the A-syntax can only access positions that are defined by A-features alone, then the features that drive priority attraction must belong fully to the A-domain. In other words, the locality profile of this system cannot be derived from intermixing with the $\bar{A}$ -domain: it must implicate A-features alone (59b).

(59) *Priority Movement: A-Syntax*

a. *Priority Positions: Visible*



b. *Priority Movement = A-Features*

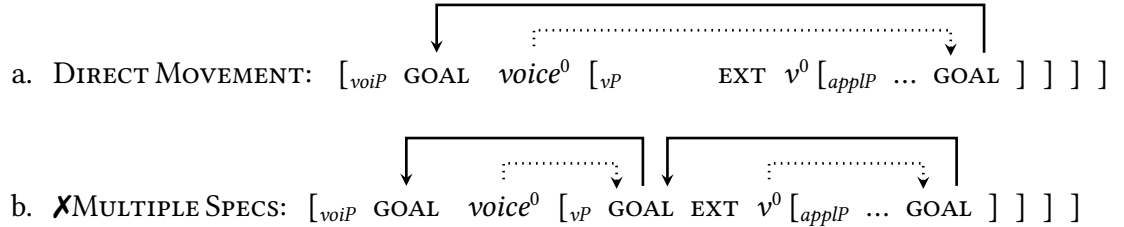


4.4 Loose Locality at the Edge

The force of this conclusion is to suggest that the A-syntax must relax the usual rules of locality to license non-local attraction to the edge of the phase. This is a conclusion that runs against the standard perspective on A-locality, which holds that it is enforced in a systematic fashion that is not relativized to position. But in wider perspective, I argue, it is one that should follow in a relatively straightforward way from the theory of cyclic spell-out put forward by Chomsky 2001—and more specifically, from the theory of Case.

To see this connection, we can return to a second pattern of A-movement to the edge of the phase: the process that draws absolutive DPs to the low subject position. In Mandar, I have proposed that this step shows the same deviation from the usual rules of A-locality: it draws ditransitive GOALS and transitive INTs from their base positions across the EXT in SPEC,VP (60a). The result is an analysis that requires a second type of non-local A-movement to SPEC,voiceP, and it contrasts in this way with an alternative that has been put forward for many languages that require the absolutive DP to raise above the ergative EXT: those that show High Absolutive Syntax, in the terminology of Coon *et al.* 2014. This is one which draws absolutive DPs above the EXT through a strictly local step of movement that places it in an outer specifier of v^0 (60b): a view first put forward by McGinnis 1998, developed for Tagalog by Rackowski 2002 and Aldridge 2004, and then extended to parallel systems in Austronesian (Erlewine, 2018; Erlewine & Levin, 2021; Erlewine & Lim, 2023; Nie, 2020; Ting, 2022, 2023) and beyond (Coon *et al.*, 2014; Royer, 2023).

(60) *Movement to the Low Subject Position: Non-Local A-Movement*



The appeal of this alternative follows from the status of ACTIVITY: the principle we leveraged in Section 2 to license non-local attraction of the absolutive DP. Despite its utility to the analysis of High Absolutive syntax, a decisive consensus has now coalesced to suggest that Activity is not a general principle of the A-syntax (Nevins, 2005; Chomsky, 2020): in the default case, the A-syntax cannot simply skip over Case-licensed DPs in this way. This is a position that has been established decisively, to my mind, by the following network of patterns: (i) many languages feature subject positions that trigger A-attraction

of arguments marked with various types of lexical Case (Zaenen *et al.*, 1985; Belletti & Rizzi, 1988; Sigurðsson, 1989; Masullo, 1992; Franks, 1995; Anagnostopoulou, 1999; Rivero, 2004; Landau, 2009) and are often explicitly unable to look past them to attract nominative objects below (Platzack, 1999; Barðdal, 1999, 2001) (ii) many ergative languages show parallel patterns of A-attraction, forcing subject positions to attract ergative arguments that receive Case in the *voiceP* (Anand & Nevins, 2006; Legate, 2006), and (iii) many languages show patterns of hyperraising that reach into finite embedded clauses to target subjects that have already received Case (Alexiadou & Anagnostopoulou, 1999; Ferreira, 2004, 2009; Nunes, 2008; Zyman, 2017, 2023; Deal, 2017; Halpert, 2019; Fong, 2019).

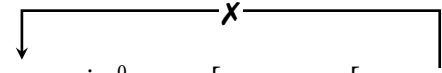
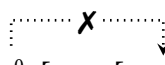
Despite the general troubles of Activity, however, it is relatively clear in Mandar that the absolutive DP must be drawn above the EXT by a single non-local step to SPEC,*voiceP*. The case for this view emerges directly from the system of priority: the facts of Absolutive Preposing show that absolutive DPs must raise to SPEC,*voiceP* (61a), priority attraction of other arguments prevents them from visibly raising to this position (61b), and in this context, they lose the ability to bind into the EXT (61c). There is thus a straightforward link from movement to SPEC,*voiceP* to movement above the EXT: absolutive DPs like the ditransitive GOAL only raise above the EXT when they are attracted to SPEC,*voiceP*.

(61) *Absolutive Arguments: Move Directly to SPEC, VoiceP*

- a. Rua i yari [*voiceP* [_{GOAL} iCicci'] na-yolo-ang [_{INT} formulir] ____].
 once 3ABS DID NAME 3ERG-show-APPL form
 'He once DID show Chichi' the forms.'
- b. Rua a' yari [*voiceP* ____ na-yolo-ang [_{EXT} iKaco'] [_{INT} pro] [_{GOAL} iCicci']].
 once 1ABS DID 3ERG-show-APPL NAME me NAME
 'Kaco' once DID show me to Chichi'.
- c. [_{TP} Na-yolo-ang nasang a' [_s kindo'-na pro] [_o pro] [_D sanaeke ____]].
 3ERG-show-APPL every 1ABS mom-3GEN her me kid *t_{nasang}*
 'Her_{*i,j} mom showed me to every_i kid.'

These facts suggest a second tension in the domain of locality: in the general case, A-movement cannot skip Case-licensed DPs, but at the edge of the Mandarin *voiceP*, it must. Returning to the theory of CYCLIC SPELL-OUT, however, there is a natural way to explain this fact. In the framework of Chomsky 2001, phase heads like *voice*⁰ are special for the fact that they impose a particular requirement on their complements: they must be emptied of all elements that will cause problems at the stage of TRANSFER. In formal terms, he proposes, this means that phase heads must force movement of all the constituents that carry unchecked features—forcing $\bar{A}$ -elements like WH-phrases to be drawn out by the edge features of Section 4.1. At this derivational moment, however, the same need for escape should fall on the class of regular DPs that lack Case: namely, the types of nominative and absolutive arguments that receive Case from the heads of the middle field. If the absolutive DP were to remain beneath the EXT until this derivational stage, then, we would thus arrive at the formal tension in (39): it should be impossible for the phase head to rescue the absolutive DP through regular A-attraction, as that process should be unable to skip the EXT (62a), but it should be equally impossible for the phase head to rescue the absolutive DP with an edge feature associated with the specification $\bar{A}$, as that second type of attraction would place it in a position defined by $\bar{A}$ -features: thus rendering it invisible to the A-syntax and blocking the requisite step of Case-assignment by T^0 (62b).

(62) *Absolutives at the Edge*

- a. *A-Movement: Strictly Local:* $\left[\text{voiceP} \text{ } ____ \text{ voice}^0_{[\bullet D \bullet]} \left[\text{VP DP}_{\text{ERG}} \left[\text{VP DP}_{\text{ABS}} \right] \right] \right]$
- 
- b. *$\bar{A}$ -Movement: Invisibility.* $\left[\text{TP } T^0 \left[\text{voiceP} \left[\bar{A}P \text{ DP}_{\text{ABS}} \right] \text{ voice}^0_{[\bullet X \bullet]} \left[\text{VP DP}_{\text{EXT}} \dots \right] \right] \right]$
- 

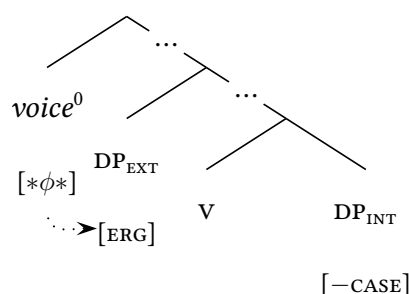
To rescue absolutive DPs in this configuration, then, I propose that the phase head must be endowed with a second type of edge feature: one that has the capacity to trigger non-local attraction and yet forms part of the A-syntax, defining positions that are visible

to the higher workings of that system. I will denote this second type of feature $[\bullet x_A \bullet]$. In the usual *voice*s of the language, it is the presence of this feature that allows this tension to be resolved and licenses the step of non-local A-attraction in (60a).

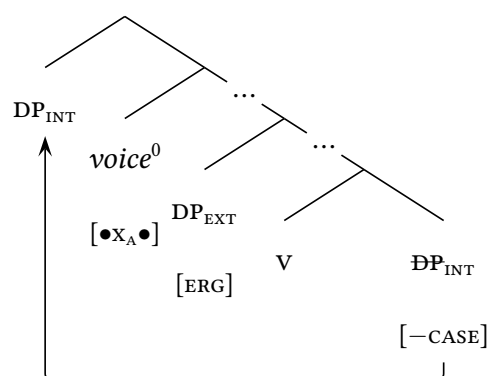
The following trees sketch out the basic derivational path. When $voice^0$ is first merged, the feature $[\bullet L \bullet]$ triggers LINK and establishes connections with all lower DPs: in the transitive *voice*s below, the EXT and the INT. To yield ergative agreement and Case-license the EXT, I assume that the derivation then proceeds to a round of AGREE: one forced by the feature $[\ast\phi\ast]$, which I take to precede MOVE as a result of its lexically-specified order on the head $voice^0$ (Heck & Müller, 2007). The head $voice^0$ thus AGREES with the EXT and assigns it Case, drawing us to the stage in (63a). The derivation then proceeds to the next feature at the root: $[\bullet x_A \bullet]$. Like $[\bullet D \bullet]$, this feature triggers MOVE and draws its targets to an A-position—but unlike that feature, it is immune to the pressure to attract the closest DP. As a result, it is free to select among its goals in response to a second constraint: the pressure to remove Caseless elements from the *voice*P. It is this second pressure that drives the step of non-local A-movement in (63b): the one that rescues the absolutive DP.

(63) *Absolutive Arguments: Rescued by A-Edge Features*

a. *Stage One: Ergative Agreement*



b. *Stage Two: A-Movement*



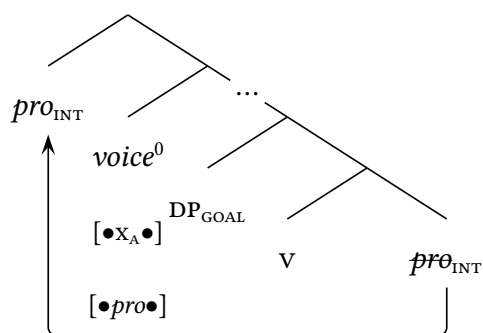
We thus arrive at a system that allows a second type of A-movement at the phase edge: one driven by the familiar class of edge features that rescue formally needy elements from

within the phase and one that leverages these to resolve a Case-theoretic tension that arises in the systems that require the heads of the middle field to license the absolutive DP. The result is a framework that extends neatly to many other High Absolutive systems where the absolutive DP has been argued to raise above the ergative DP at exactly the edge of the clause-internal phase (in Austronesian: Rackowski 2002; Aldridge 2004; Nomoto 2013, 2015; Erlewine 2018; Erlewine & Levin 2021; Nie 2020; Ting 2023).

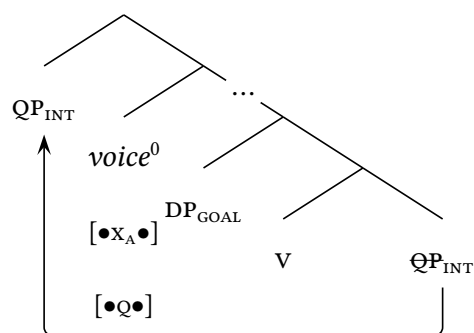
Turning back to the system of priority, at last, we can leverage the same features to draw priority parcels to the edge. At the derivational stage where movement plays out, more specifically, we might imagine that the preference to rescue Caseless DPs is somehow overruled by the pressure to multitask and parasitically check $[\bullet pro \bullet]$ and $[\bullet x \bullet]$ —forcing $[\bullet x_A \bullet]$ to raise pronouns (64a) and QPs (64b) instead. It is the task of the following section, then, to understand how these effects might unfold without causing problems of Case.

(64) *Absolutive Arguments: Rescued by A-Edge Features*

a. *Pronominal Priority*



b. *Quantifier Priority*

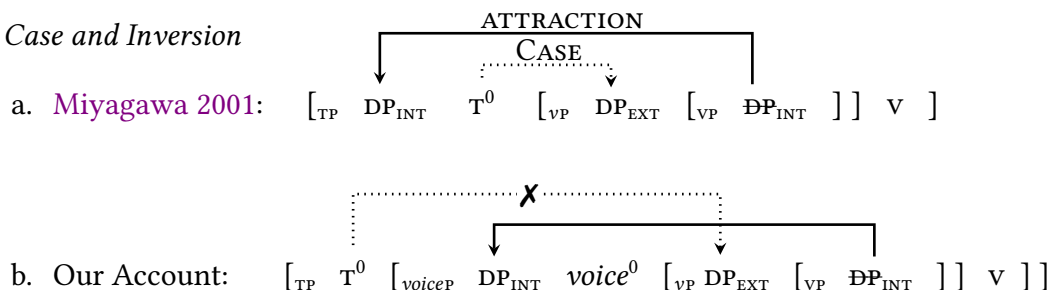


5 Secondary Licensors and Anti-Agreement

Generalizing the results of our work so far, we thus arrive at a perspective on A-inversions that differs in important respects from the proposals Miyagawa 2001 and Bailyn 2004. Across the systems where A-movement can skip its usual targets and trigger special patterns of attraction that feed the A-syntax, specifically, we can advance three claims: (i) inversions must emerge from a type of Economy that forces the attraction of xps with specific features, rather than following in certain configurations as a free choice; (ii) inversions must implicate non-local A-movement, rather than Equidistance, and (iii) because this type of A-movement is keyed to features that fall at the edge of the phase, inversions must occur in a restricted set of positions: the edges of the VP and CP.

This final theoretical claim—that inversions must operate at the edge of the phase—is important for the way in which it reshapes the problem of Case. Miyagawa 2001 and Bailyn 2004 both propose that inversions operate at the level of the TP, and as a result, their accounts preserve a path for the assignment of Case: when T^0 passes up the subject for movement, it can still AGREE with that DP and assign it Case (65a). If we situate inversion at the edge of the *voiceP*, however, we arrive at a different result: when inversions pass up the subject, they sever a link along the usual derivational path that allows this argument to receive Case. By preventing it from raising to the edge, more specifically, this system prevents the subject from reaching the position that feeds interaction with the heads of the middle field—and traps it in a domain of transfer without Case (65b).

(65) *Case and Inversion*



The result is an account that imposes a secondary requirement on systems of inversion: when the A-syntax strands the types of nominative and absolutive DPs that rely on functional heads outside the extended VP for Case, it must provide those elements with an exceptional path to licensing in the clause-internal phase. Restricting our attention to the Mandarin system of PRIORITY, the task of this section is to show that such a path exists.

5.1 Conflicting Priorities and Low Agreement

The case begins from the class of *voices⁰* that host priority parcels of two different types. In the general case in Mandarin, we see strictly local attraction when the INT and GOAL are priority parcels of the same types. When both elements are pronouns, for instance, *voice⁰* must attract the GOAL, and when both are quantified, the facts are the same (50a). When the two arguments contrast, however, we see a secondary effect. When the GOAL is a QP and the INT a pronoun, *voice⁰* attracts the GOAL (66a). But if the GOAL is a pronoun and the INT a QP, *voice⁰* skips the pronominal GOAL to target the quantified INT (66b).

(66) *Quantifiers > Pronouns*

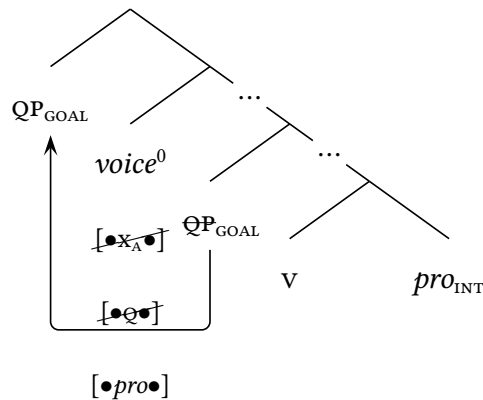
- a. [TP [D Ing. sola-na] na-yolo-ang i [s iCicci'] [o pro]].
 all friend-3GEN 3ERG-show-APPL 3ABS NAME him
 ‘Cicci’ showed him to all of her friends.
- b. [TP [o Ing. lukisan-na] na-yolo-ang i [s iCicci'] [D pro]].
 all painting-3GEN 3ERG-show-APPL 3ABS NAME him
 ‘Cicci’ showed him all of her paintings.

In narrow perspective, this pattern suggests that the head *voice⁰* imposes a secondary and idiosyncratic type of preference in the system of PRIORITY: when faced with the choice of satisfying [$\bullet$ Q $\bullet$] and [$\bullet$ pro $\bullet$], it must select the targets that satisfy [$\bullet$ Q $\bullet$] (67). This second layer of preference seems unlinked to the system of Economy, as there is no clear way to derive it from the logic of Multitasking (for instance, by positing some type of

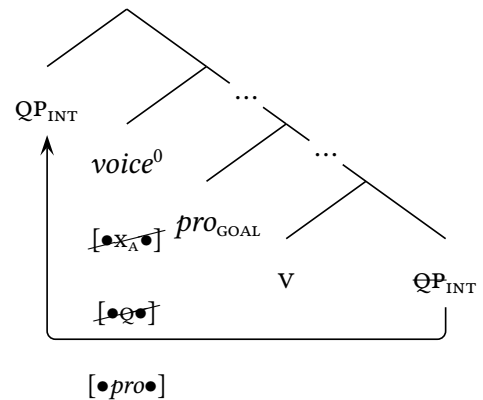
containment relationship between $[\bullet Q \bullet]$ and $[\bullet pro \bullet]$). But it is of a kind with the types of head-specific preference that are imposed by heads in the system of ϕ -agreement, which frequently follow idiosyncratic scales of the same type (Coon & Bale, 2014).

(67) *Quantified Phrases: Higher Priority*

a. *Regular Attraction*



b. *Priority Attraction*



When we introduce slightly more structure into the clauses in (66), however, we come to a second and more important result. In the clauses that lack preverbal auxiliaries, the right edge of the verbal complex is forced to host the absolutive agreement enclitics (9). But this pattern of linearization turns out to mask a second effect: when absolutive agreement is allowed to dock on higher auxiliaries in clauses like (66b), the right edge of the verb begins to host agreement with the pronominal GOALS skipped by *voice*⁰.

(68) *Low Agreement: Stranded Pronominal GOALS*

- a. $[_{TP} [_{O} \text{Ing. seni}] \text{ rua } \mathbf{i} \quad [_{voiceP} \text{na-yolo-ang} \quad \mathbf{o} \quad [_{s} \text{iCicci'}] [_{D} \text{pro}]]]$.
all art once 3ABS 3ERG-show-APPL 2ACC NAME you
‘Cicci’ once showed you all of the art.’
- b. $[_{TP} [_{O} \text{I’o mie’ ing.}] \text{ rua } \mathbf{o} \quad [_{voip} \text{na-yolo-ang} \quad \mathbf{i} \quad [_{s} \text{iCicci'}] [_{D} \text{pro}]]]$.
you PL all once 2ABS 3ERG-show-APPL 3ACC NAME him
‘Cicci’ once showed you all to him.’

The enclitics that spell out this second type of agreement are segmentally identical to the enclitics that spell out absolutive agreement in τ^0 , but they contrast with them syntactically in many respects. Most importantly, they show a difference in position: the low agreement enclitics must follow the verb. In clauses that host multiple auxiliaries, then, they retain their postverbal position and cannot climb to any higher auxiliary (69).

(69) *Low Agreement: Strictly Postverbal*

$\downarrow$ $\downarrow$
 $[_{TP} [_{O} \text{Ing. seni}] \text{rua } \mathbf{i} \quad \mathbf{yari} [_{voiceP} \text{na-yolo-ang} \quad \mathbf{a'} \quad [_{s} \text{iCicci'}] [_{D} \text{pro}]]]]$.
all art once 3ABS DID 3ERG-show-APPL 1ACC NAME me
‘Cicci’ once DID show me all of the art.’

In the same vein, the low agreement enclitics show a second distributional restriction: they only appear when $voice^0$ passes up pronouns of this type. As a result, this type of agreement does not appear in the $voicePs$ where $voice^0$ strands regular DPs in the position of the GOAL (70a), but it is required when $voice^0$ strands pronouns in that position (70b).

(70) *Low Agreement: Only with Pronouns*

$\downarrow$ $\downarrow$
a. $[_{TP} [_{O} \text{Ing. seni}] \text{rua } \mathbf{i} \quad [_{voiP} \text{na-yolo-ang} \quad (*\mathbf{i}) \quad [_{s} \text{iCicci'}] [_{D} \text{iKaco'}]]]]$.
all art once 3ABS 3ERG-show-APPL 3ACC NAME NAME
‘Cicci’ once showed Kaco’ all of the art.’
 $\downarrow$ $\downarrow$
b. $[_{TP} [_{O} \text{Ing. seni}] \text{rua } \mathbf{i} \quad [_{voiP} \text{na-yolo-ang} \quad *(\mathbf{i}) \quad [_{s} \text{iCicci'}] [_{D} \text{pro}]]]]$.
all art once 3ABS 3ERG-show-APPL 3ACC NAME him
‘Cicci’ once showed him all of the art.’

Third and finally, the low agreement enclitics emerge strictly in contexts of priority. Pronominal GOALS never trigger this type of agreement in regular non-finite clauses, like the control complement in (71a). In those non-finite clause, moreover, it is always impossible for an overt ditransitive GOAL to appear (71b): a restriction that follows from the hypothesis that these structures cannot assign Case to the absolutive DP (Brodkin, 2022).

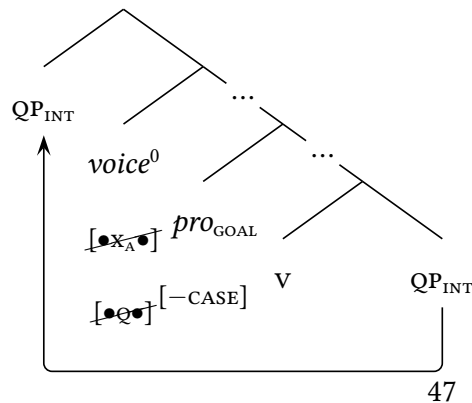
(71) *Low Agreement: Restricted to the System of Priority*

- a. Batabata i iKaco' [_{voiceP} u-bengang (*i) [_{INT} do tugas] [_D PRO] o].
 reluctant 3ABS NAME 1ERG-give 3ACC that task him there
 'Kaco' is reluctant for me to give him that task.'
- b. *Batabata i iKaco' [_{voiceP} u-bengang (i) [_{INT} pro] [_D ia]].
 reluctant 3ABS NAME 1ERG-give 3ACC it him
 'Kaco' is reluctant for me to give it to him.'

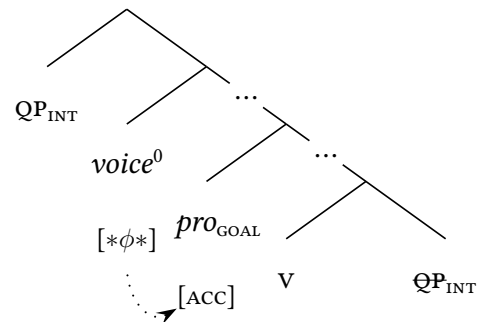
To capture these facts, then, I propose that these low agreement enclitics reflect a type of SECONDARY LICENSOR, in the terminology of [Levin & Massam 1985](#); [Bobaljik 1993](#); [Laka 1993](#); [Rezac 2010](#): one that assigns Case to the ditransitive GOAL whenever it is cut off from the middle field and forced to stay in the *voiceP*. In light of their low position and link to inversion, I propose that they originate in *voice*⁰. In the ditransitive *voice*⁰s where that head attracts the INT, I propose that they are systematically mobilized to resolve the problem of licensing in (72a): whenever the GOAL is stranded without Case, it triggers the pattern of AGREE in (72b). This is one that must only be expounded when its target is a pronoun, and it is one that must be suppressed in the morphology under linear adjacency with absolutive agreement in T⁰. But in the syntax, it is one that has a consistent effect: when the GOAL is kept low by PRIORITY, it provides that DP with a secondary path to Case.

(72) *Stranded Goals: Low Agreement*

a. *Stage One: Priority*



b. *Stage Two: Licensing*



5.2 The Ordering Account

Our final task is thus to build a theory of how this agreement might emerge. We can begin from the hypothesis that its distribution must be determined in purely derivational terms and cannot be forced by the logic of transderivational comparison (Safir, 1993; Chomsky, 1995), which is often evoked in the analysis of secondary licensors. In the same vein, our solution must also obey the INCLUSIVENESS CONDITION (Chomsky, 1995): the requirement that no material be introduced in the course of the derivation.

To meet these desiderata, I propose that this pattern of low agreement is forced by a feature that is systematically present on *voice*⁰. In the derivations where the INT is raised to SPEC,*voiceP* with priority, these features select the GOAL in a regular way and assign it Case. But in the derivations where the GOAL is raised, for reasons that we must understand, this pattern of AGREE is derailed and the same type of Case cannot be assigned—ruling out the presence of overt GOALS in non-finite *voiceP*s and forcing the GOAL to receive Case from τ^0 . The result is that we can understand its distribution to turn on a type of ANTI-AGREEMENT EFFECT (Ouhalla, 1993): these features target and Case-license the GOALS that remains low (73a) but fails to target and license those that raise to SPEC,*voiceP* (73b).

(73) Low Agreement: the Anti-Agreement Analysis

- a. *Goals Low: Success:* $[_{voiceP} \text{ DP}_{INT} \text{ voice}^0 [_{VP} \text{ DP}_{EXT} \text{ DP}_{INT} \text{ DP}_{GOAL}]]$
- b. *Goals Move: Failure:* $[_{voiceP} \text{ DP}_{GOAL} \text{ voice}^0 [_{VP} \text{ DP}_{EXT} \text{ DP}_{INT} \text{ DP}_{GOAL}]]$
-

To understand this effect, we can turn to the wider network of cases where A-movement seems to render elements invisible to AGREE. Across a wide range of systems, it has been argued that the traces left by A-movement must be invisible to this operation: thus τ^0 has been argued to skip past the traces of A-moved dative subjects to target nominative objects in Icelandic (Holmberg & Hróarsdóttir 2003; Sigurðsson & Holmberg 2008; Chomsky

2008, and on similar effects in Faroese: [Asarina 2011](#)), to skip the traces of A-moved nominative subjects to target accusative objects in Passamaquoddy ([Bruening, 2005](#), 19-20) and varieties of Neo-Aramaic ([Kalin & Van Urk, 2015](#)), to skip the traces of A-moved ergatives to target absolutive objects in Hindi ([Anand & Nevins, 2006](#)), to skip the traces of clitic-doubled genitives to attract nominative objects in Greek ([Anagnostopoulou 2003](#); and on analogous effects elsewhere: [Béjar & Rezac 2003](#), [Halpert 2012](#), 193-195). [Richards 2013](#), at last, lays out an especially relevant pattern of this type: when τ^0 attracts arguments to SPEC,TP in Lardil, it ceases to AGREE with them for the purposes of tense concord. Thus there are arguments that agree with τ^0 when they remain low, like the INT in (74a), but cease to trigger the same agreement when they undergo A-movement to SPEC,TP (74b).

(74) *Lardil: A-Movement Bleeds Case-Assignment*

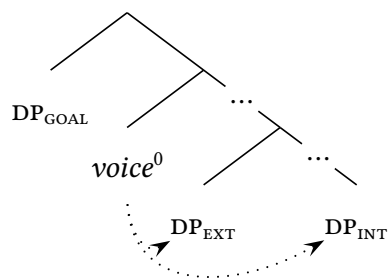
- a. $[_{TP}$ Ngawa τ^0 $[_{FP}$ be-thu bidngen-**thu**]].
 dog bite-FUT woman-FUT
 ‘The dog will bite the woman.’ [Richards 2013](#), 56a
- b. $[_{TP}$ Bidngen__ τ^0 $[_{FP}$ be-yi-thu bidngen__]].
 woman bite-WILL-FUT
 ‘The woman will be bitten.’ [Richards 2013](#), 56b
-

The standard account takes these effects to emerge from the interaction of two parts: (i) a lexical ordering of features on a single head, such that it triggers MOVE before AGREE, and (ii) a relational constraint which demands that AGREE target the heads of chains and ignore all lower links ([Chomsky 2001](#); see also [Béjar & Rezac 2003](#); [Anagnostopoulou 2003](#); [Holmberg & Hróarsdóttir 2003](#); [Sigurðsson & Holmberg 2008](#); [Richards 2013](#); [Kalin & Van Urk 2015](#); for alternative perspectives: [Rezac 2004](#); [van Koppen 2005](#); [Georgi 2014](#)). On the framework developed here, we can understand this effect to turn on a disruption of the pathways built by LINK: whenever a head attracts a goals, it severs its connection

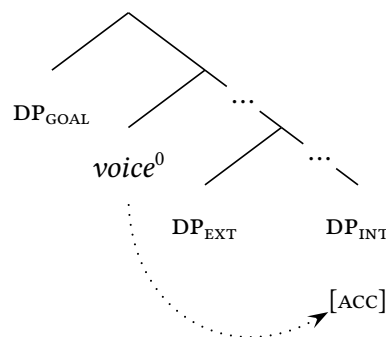
with the lower instance of that element. The following diagrams show how this analysis derives our result: in a regular ditransitive *voice*_P, the head *voice*⁰ draws up the GOAL and proceeds to the feature [ϕ ∗] with the lines of connection in (75a): it only has access to the EXT and INT. As the EXT is consistently Case-licensed by the ergative agreement probe on *voice*⁰, the ensuing step of AGREE is forced to target the INT—yielding the canonical path to licensing in the ditransitive for that DP (75b).

(75) *The Anti-Agreement Effect*

a. *The Remaining Connections*



b. *Low Agreement* → INT



6 Conclusion

With the final pieces of the analysis in place, we can now step back to take stock on the theory of the A-syntax that emerges from this work. The facts of priority suggest that there are steps of selective and non-local attraction that operate within the A-syntax: steps that show the locality profile of $\bar{A}$ -attraction, the binding profile of A-movement, and unlike the operations beneath A-scrambling and clitic doubling, feed higher A-movement and ϕ -agreement in a regular way. I have argued that these steps implicate a second type of A-movement: one that is localized to the edge of the phase and driven by a second class of Edge Features that are independently required to draw up absolutive arguments from low positions within the *voice*_P. To resolve the problems of Case that emerge when

these arguments are passed up, I have proposed that inversions can only emerge when the A-syntax has the capacity to deploy a secondary line of licensing to rescue the elements it traps in the clause-internal phase. To capture the fine patterns of preference in this system, at last, I have argued that A-movement must play out in a calculus that mirrors that of AGREE: one that is preceded by an operation that links heads with multiple possible goals and guided by constraints of economy and the idiosyncratic preferences of heads. The combined force of these proposals is to refine our understanding of a single empirical system and simultaneously deliver a general theory of how inversions might emerge.

The ensuing perspective is one that reshapes our understanding of many systems across the A-syntax, and the first of these surrounds the role of the phase edge. If non-local A-attraction must operate at the edge, we should predict that it will only be able to skip over Case-marked arguments at the edge: a stance that fits neatly with the results of work on High Absolutive systems and one that may resolve the empirical issues that haunt the classical Activity Condition. The same stance forces us to rethink other patterns of inversion as well: on this view, they too must emerge at the same edge and deliver corresponding paths to secondary licensing.

Further possibilities then emerge from the claim that a second type of A-movement emerges at the edge. For instance, there are patterns to suggest that restrictions on category are loosened in this position as well: in Mandar clauses like (76), to provide one example, the usual lines of evidence suggest that the low subject position attracts a PP.

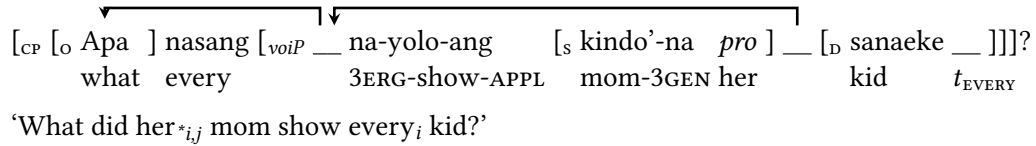
(76) *Phase Edge: Further Divergences in A-Movement*

Ndang i rua [voiceP [PP **dospenn-na lao**] na-kiring-ang draf ____]].
 not 3ABS ever advisor-3GEN to 3ERG-send-APPL draft
 ‘He never sent a draft to his advisor.’

The highest mysteries that emerge from this investigation, however, are those that fall at the frontiers of the A- $\bar{A}$ divide. The first surrounds the cases where inversion seems to

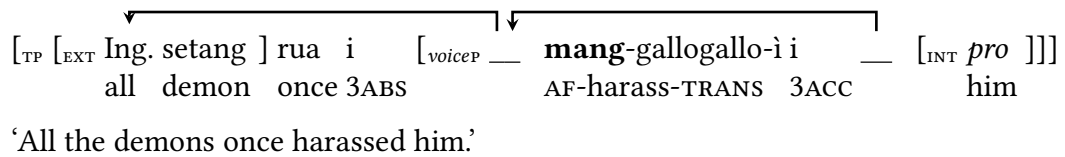
operate in response to elements from the $\bar{A}$ -domain. In the ditransitive Mandarin *voiceps* where the INT is a WH-phrase, for instance, we see the telltale signature of priority: the facts of variable binding, for instance, show that the GOAL exceptionally stays below the EXT (77). It is thus tempting to imagine that all of these interactions implicate priority A-attraction as well—allowing the label of mixed A- $\bar{A}$ movement to be restricted to that set of processes that fail to feed the higher A-syntax (Webelhuth 1989a; cf. Van Urk 2015).

(77) *WH-INTs: Derail Binding from the GOAL into the EXT*



The final puzzle that emerges in this domain is one left untouched through this work: the A-syntax that emerges when certain priority parcels take the position of the EXT. From that position in Mandarin, both quantified nominals and WH-phrases are drawn up in a way that forces the total loss of ergative agreement and the emergence of a construction known as the AGENT FOCUS (78): a central focus of comparative work on ergativity (Coon *et al.* 2014, Coon *et al.* 2021). It remains to be seen what truths may emerge from this fact.

(78) *Priority EXTs: the Agent Focus*



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